

Erasure



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF PERCIVAL EVERETT

Percival Everett was born in Fort Gordon, Georgia, where his father was a sergeant in the U.S. Army. He grew up in Columbia, South Carolina and attended college at the University of Miami, where he earned a bachelor's in philosophy. He went on to attend Brown University, where he graduated with an M.A. in fiction in 1982. *Suder*, his first novel, was published in 1983. Over the course of his prolific career, Everett has published over 20 novels, four short story collections, and several books of poetry, among other works. His stories have been published in *Best American Short Stories*. His most recent novel, [James](#), a reworking of *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, told from the enslaved man Jim's perspective, was published in 2024. Everett has received numerous literary awards for his work, including the Guggenheim Fellowship in Fiction (2015), the Academy Award in Literature from The American Academy of Arts and Letters, and the Dos Passos Prize. He was a finalist for the 2021 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his 2020 novel, *Telephone*. Everett lives in Los Angeles with his wife, the novelist Danzy Senna, and their children.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Erasure (and *My Pafology*, the novella Monk writes in *Erasure*) is a parody of so-called "Black" fiction, which in the novel describes stories that take place in an urban setting and portray the struggles of Black characters who display a number of exaggerated, offensive stereotypes often attributed to Black people living in poverty. This genre of writing is a subset of urban fiction, a literary genre that takes place in a city or urban area and focuses on the lives of characters who exist on the margins of society, highlighting the often bleak, violent reality of their experience in a frank, raw style. The origins of the genre trace back to the realist novels of 18th-century realist writers like Theodore Dreiser and Stephen Crane, who both wrote novels that depicted the harsh reality of urban living. The Harlem Renaissance movement of the 20th century continued this tradition, with writers like the poet Langston Hughes writing about the struggles of life in Harlem, New York City, from an African American perspective. Contemporary urban fiction is largely written by African American authors, a tradition that may be traced back to the Black Power movement of the 1970s, a social movement that emphasized racial pride among Black Americans and led to an embrace of Black art and culture.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Erasure employs elements of parody and metafiction, with protagonist Monk representing, one could argue, a fictionalized version of the book's author, Percival Everett—just as Monk, in *Erasure*, writes a fictionalized version of himself in the character Stagg R. Leigh. Everett frequently incorporates elements of metafiction into his works, many of which, like *Erasure*, examine themes of race, identity, and identity construction. Everett's *I Am Not Sidney Poitier* follows a protagonist named Not Sidney Poitier—who resembles the real-life actor Sidney Poitier—as he grapples with issues that stem from identity and race. *Percival Everett by Virgil Russell: A Novel*, meanwhile, is about a man whose elderly father writes a novel from his son's (i.e., the protagonist's) perspective. Everett's most recent novel, [James](#), published in 2024, is a reworking of *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, told from the enslaved man Jim's perspective. *My Pafology* (later titled *Fuck*), which Monk writes in *Erasure*, is a parody of works written in heavy African American vernacular that (at least according to Monk) over-rely on exaggerated, negative stereotypes of African American people and Black suffering. Real books that Monk cites as examples of this so-called "ghetto fiction" include [Native Son](#) by Richard Wright, about a young Black man living in poverty in Chicago's South Side; and *Push* by Sapphire, about an illiterate, pregnant Black teenager growing up in poverty in Harlem.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Erasure*
- **When Published:** 2001
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Parody
- **Setting:** Washington, D. C.; Annapolis, Maryland; New York, New York; Los Angeles, California
- **Climax:** *Fuck*, the parody Monk writes as a scathing critique of the publishing industry, ironically and infuriatingly wins *The Book Award*.
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

American Fiction. In 2023, a film adaptation of *Erasure*, *American Fiction*, was released to high critical acclaim. The film, which was written and directed by American filmmaker Cord Jefferson, was nominated for several Academy Awards, including Best Adapted Screenplay, which it won.

Metafiction. Everett shares many traits in common with *Erasure*'s protagonist, Monk Ellison. Not only are they both writers, but Everett, like Monk, has also published multiple

reworkings of Greek literature, including *For Her Dark Skin*, a reworking of Euripides's [Medea](#).



PLOT SUMMARY

Thelonious “Monk” Ellison is an author and professor of English literature. Though Black himself, he claims not to believe in race, citing a number of ways in which he doesn’t fit the mold of the stereotypical Black American: he didn’t grow up in the inner city or rural south, for instance, and he’s not great at basketball. Still, he realizes that there are some bigoted people who wish to harm him because of the color of his skin, and so he allows that, according to society’s standards, he is Black. He’s also annoyed that the publishing industry expects him to write books that engage with stereotypical depictions of “Black” suffering—he prefers to write complex reworkings of ancient Greek dramas, which don’t sell all that well, and he’s sick of constantly being told that his writing isn’t “black enough.” He becomes more irate as he follows the praise (and commercial success) of a new book, Juanita Mae Jenkins’s *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto*, which embodies everything Monk detests about the sort of “Black” writing that appeals to publishers and mainstream audiences.

Monk’s story begins in Washington, D.C.—his hometown—where he has traveled to speak at a literary conference. While in Washington, Monk visits with his older sister Lisa—a doctor who performs abortions for low-income women—and Mother, who still lives with the family’s longtime housekeeper, Lorraine, in the house Monk grew up in. During his short stay at home, Monk witnesses firsthand Mother’s declining health: she is displaying clear signs of early Alzheimer’s disease.

Not long after Monk returns to California, where he teaches as a university professor, he receives word that Lisa has unexpectedly died—an anti-abortion protestor shot her at work. Bereft, Monk returns to Washington for Lisa’s funeral and to take over her responsibility of managing Mother’s care and finances. Monk also reunites with his brother, Bill, whom he hasn’t spoken with in years. Bill lives in Arizona and is recently estranged from his wife and children after his wife found out he’s gay. He’s presently going through a messy, costly divorce and can’t afford to help Monk with Mother’s care.

Monk decides to put his life in California on hold to move back in with Mother and Lorraine. After Mother’s condition becomes too much for Monk to handle on his own, he takes her to a doctor who recommends moving mother to a care facility. However, while on leave from work and with no publishers agreeing to take on his latest novel, Monk struggles to afford care for his ailing mother.

In a moment of acute frustration, Monk pens *My Pafology*, a parody of the so-called “ghetto fiction” he so detests, writing

under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh. He submits the novella to his bemused agent, Yul, who reluctantly passes along the manuscript to editors. To Monk’s shock—and horror—the manuscript receives laudatory praise, and he soon receives an offer of \$600,000 in advance payments from a major publishing house that wishes to publish *My Pafology*.

Reluctant to pass on this much-needed cash but unwilling to further discredit his reputation by attaching his name to the work, Monk decides to pretend to be the fictitious Stagg Leigh in his interactions with the publishers, producers, and talk show hosts who are so captivated by *My Pafology*, playing the part of a gruff ex-con who grew up rough and now wishes to share the real, unfiltered story of Black life in America. In time, Monk’s double life takes a toll on his emotional state, and he suffers a crisis of identity as he considers the ramifications of compromising on his artistic integrity and perpetuating the stereotypes about Black artists and Black life that he finds so offensive. In anger, he antagonistically demands that the novella’s title be changed to *Fuck*. Implausibly, the publishing house agrees.

As Mother’s health continues to decline, Monk takes her and Lorraine to the family beach house in Annapolis, Maryland, for one last vacation before Monk decides it’s time to move Mother into a care facility. There, he strikes up a brief relationship with Marilyn, a local woman, which ends disastrously. Not long after the breakup, a chaotic incident with Mother convinces Monk that her health has finally gotten too difficult for him to manage, so he moves her into a care facility near the family home. He continues to live at the family home so he can visit Mother regularly, though her health continues to decline.

Meanwhile, Monk’s time home forces him to reevaluate certain aspects of his childhood and family history. When he goes through a box of his deceased father’s personal papers and discovers that his father had been having an affair with a white woman—and fathered a child with her—his idealized vision of his father shatters, and he’s forced to consider how the clear favoritism Monk’s father directed toward Monk skewed Monk’s impression of the man and influenced Monk’s own identity and way of looking at the world.

Fuck, meanwhile, continues to receive glowing praise from readers and critics alike. Monk is invited to serve on a panel of judges for a prestigious literary award, *The Book Award*. Much to his chagrin, *Fuck* is among the works submitted for consideration. He tries to convince the other judges of the book’s obvious flaws and offensive content, but his arguments fall on deaf ears, and the panel (minus Monk) selects *Fuck* as the winner of *The Book Award*.

Monk attends the National Book Association ceremony along with the other judges and the wealthy donors who fund *The Book Award*. When *Fuck* is announced as that year’s winner,

Monk—to everyone’s great confusion—slowly makes his way to the stage to accept the prize as the novella’s elusive author, Stagg R. Leigh. He reaches the podium and looks straight into the cameras before him. “Egads, I’m on television,” he proclaims.

house she raised her children in. Her husband—Monk’s father—died seven years before the novel’s present. Mother displays early signs of Alzheimer’s disease that worsen over the course of the book. After Lisa’s sudden death, Monk puts his life in California on hold and moves back in with Mother and the family’s long-term housekeeper, Lorraine. Eventually Mother’s health deteriorates to the point that Monk is no longer able to care for her on his own, and he sends her to live in a care facility, visiting her daily. The novel draws an implicit comparison between the “erasure” of the self that Mother experiences as her Alzheimer’s progresses and the “erasure” that Monk experiences as his performance as Stagg R. Leigh forces him to confront his own complicated relationship with race and racial identity.

Lorraine – Lorraine is the Ellison family’s longtime housekeeper—she’s worked for the family since before Monk was born. Although Monk knows he must move Mother into a care facility due to her worsening Alzheimer’s symptoms, he feels an obligation to look out for Lorraine and worries what will become of her once she no longer has a job working for the family. Monk convinces Lorraine to accompany him and Mother to the Ellison family beach house in Annapolis as a send-off for Mother. There, Lorraine reconnects with Maynard, a local man, and a romance develops between them. The couple, aware of their old age, decides to get married then and there, with Monk serving as Maynard’s best man and Mother serving as Lorraine’s matron of honor. However, Mother’s Alzheimer’s causes her to become confused and belligerent at the wedding, and she inadvertently says cruel things about Lorraine that make Lorraine cry. Ultimately, this incident is the tipping point for Monk, and he immediately makes arrangements to move Mother into the care facility.

Lisa – Lisa is Monk’s sister. She’s a doctor at a clinic that provides reproductive healthcare—including abortions—to underprivileged women. As the only sibling still living in D.C., Lisa is forced to manage Mother’s care and finances by herself, a situation she finds unfair. Monk and Lisa don’t have an especially close relationship, but they each love and support the other, even if they don’t always understand where the other is coming from. Unlike Bill, who harbors some resentment over their father’s obvious favoritism toward Monk, Lisa doesn’t hold this against Monk. She even affirms that Father was right to hold Monk in high regard—Monk is special, and she loves him for that. Lisa dies unexpectedly after an anti-abortion protestor fires a shotgun into the clinic. After her death, Monk moves back into Mother’s house to take over her care and finances.

Bill – Bill is Monk’s brother. He lives in Arizona and works as a plastic surgeon. In the novel’s present, Bill is in the middle of a messy divorce, the consequence of his wife finding out that he is gay (though according to Monk, “we all knew he was gay”). As a result of the emotional and financial strain of the divorce—and Bill’s new freedom to openly explore his identity



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Thelonious “Monk” Ellison – Thelonious “Monk” Ellison is *Erasure*’s protagonist and narrator. He is a professor of English and a writer who has published several well-received novels, though he struggles to achieve much commercial success in an industry that has little interest in the complex, theoretical reworkings of ancient Greek dramas he prefers to write. As a Black author, he is repeatedly encouraged to write “Black” books—that is, books that rely on exaggerated stereotypes of Black struggle in America. Monk finds this genre of literature offensive, and he dismisses authors like Juanita Mae Jenkins as inauthentic, talentless hacks. After Monk’s sister Lisa dies unexpectedly, Monk puts his life in California on hold to move back in with Mother, who is showing early signs of Alzheimer’s. But Mother’s inevitable move to a care facility puts Monk under financial strain, and in a fit of desperation and rage, he pens *My Pafology*, a parody on the inane (but commercially successful) “Black” literature he so hates, under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh. To Monk’s horror, the novel receives instant high praise from critics and readers alike. And although it disgusts him to compromise on his artistic integrity, he cannot bring himself to turn down the generous advance payments that publishers (and later Hollywood producers) offer him. Too ashamed to admit to his hackery outright, he assumes the Stagg R. Leigh identity in his interactions with publishing industry people, and what starts out as a cynical game ultimately forces Monk to reevaluate his attitude toward race, racial identity, and authenticity.

Stagg R. Leigh – Stagg R. Leigh is the pseudonym under which Monk pens *My Pafology*, which he later retitles *Fuck*. Ashamed at the thought of others deeming him a sell-out, Monk decides to play the part of Stagg in his interactions with the various editors, publishers, and producers interested in securing the rights to his novella. The Stagg persona Monk acts out is an exaggerated stereotype of a hardened Black criminal whose rough, underprivileged upbringing has denied him opportunities for economic and self-improvement—until now. Echoing praise directed toward other works of so-called “Black” fiction, critics laud *Fuck* as a “true, raw, gritty work” that adeptly captures the reality of Black American life. After the novel inexplicably wins *The Book Award*, Monk, to everyone’s great confusion, walks onstage to accept the award, implicitly revealing himself as the elusive Stagg Leigh.

Mother – Monk’s mother lives in Washington, D.C., in the

as a gay man for the first time in his life—Bill is unable to contribute much to Mother’s care, leaving Monk to handle things on his own. Monk harbors resentment toward Bill for his failure to step up, though his bitterness ultimately seems to stem from his jealousy over Bill’s ability to be honest about who he truly is and his bravery to present his true self to the world.

Father – Monk’s father, Benjamin Ellison, was a doctor who died several years before the novel’s present. Father held his children to high standards. Though Lisa, Bill, and Monk all grew up to have successful careers, Father clearly favored Monk and regarded him as special, a fact that wasn’t lost on Monk, his siblings, or their mother. Throughout the book, Monk gradually comes to understand how his admiration for his father skewed his perception of the man, exaggerating his father’s good qualities and blinding Monk to his flaws. Though he never expresses it outright, Monk seems to realize how his father’s internalized racism may have influenced Monk’s own ideas about race, his artistic sensibilities, and his harsh condemnation of so-called “Black” literature like *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto*.

Kenya Dunston – Kenya Dunston is a talk show host who has Juanita Mae Jenkins on her show to sing the praises of Jenkins’s new novel. She later has Monk (as Stagg R. Leigh) on the show to promote *My Pafology/Fuck*. Monk tries to sabotage the interview, refusing to cooperate with Kenya and giving one-word answers to her questions.

Juanita Mae Jenkins – Juanita Mae Jenkins is a Black author whose debut novel, *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto*, receives glowing praise from critics and mainstream audiences alike—and immense critical success. Monk loathes the book, Jenkins, and authors like her, who he feels are hacks who write offensive books that rely on tired stereotypes of Black people to make money. In anger, Monk writes *My Pafology*, a satire of *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto* and books like it, under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh. To Monk’s shock and disgust, publishers fail to recognize his novella for the parody it clearly is, and it receives glowing reviews and movie deals just as Jenkins’s work did before it.

Yul – Yul is Monk’s agent. He is perpetually the bearer of bad news for Monk, whose complex, experimental style of writing is of little interest to major publishing houses or the readership they cater to. Yul puts in plain terms what editors only allude to: Monk’s writing simply isn’t “Black” enough to achieve commercial success in today’s culture. Yul is wary (albeit slightly bemused) when Monk submits his manuscript for *My Pafology*, a parody of the so-called “ghetto fiction” Monk so derides, written under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh. But when publishing houses respond with unprecedented enthusiasm, offering Monk (and by extension Yul) a half million dollars in advance payments, he urges Monk to swallow his pride and accept the deal. However, he is less keen on Monk’s risky and bizarre choice to play the part of Stagg R. Leigh rather than admitting that he, Monk, wrote *My Pafology*.

Marilyn Tilman – Marilyn Tilman is a woman who lives in Annapolis, Maryland, where the Ellisons own a beach house. Monk meets her when he, Mother, and Lorraine are in town for a final vacation before it’s time to move Mother into a care facility due to her worsening Alzheimer’s symptoms. Marilyn and Monk strike up a brief romance that ends after Monk spots a copy of Juanita Mae Jenkins’s *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto* on Marilyn’s table and confronts her about it, insulting the book and characterizing people who read it as stupid.

Gretchen – Gretchen is Monk’s half-sister. She is the daughter of Fiona, a woman whom Monk’s father had an affair with while serving overseas. Monk’s father lost contact with Fiona and Gretchen after Fiona broke off the affair and ordered Monk’s father not to contact her. He wrote Gretchen a heartfelt letter but never sent it. Monk eventually tracks Gretchen down and introduces himself, but Gretchen receives him coldly—she has lived a rough life of struggle compared to Monk’s privileged upbringing and feels bitterness toward Monk’s father for never trying to find her. Monk writes Gretchen a check for \$100,000 and claims his father meant for Gretchen to have it, though he knows it won’t undo any of the damage his father wrought.

Maynard – Maynard is an older man who works as a guard in the town where the Ellisons own a summer house. He reconnects with Lorraine when she, Monk, and Mother spend a few weeks at the beach house as a last vacation for Mother before it’s time to move her into an assisted living center. A romance soon develops between Maynard and Lorraine, and they decide to get married on that same vacation.

Wiley Morgenstein – Wiley Morgenstein is a Hollywood producer who meets with Monk (as Stagg R. Leigh) to discuss plans for a film adaptation of *My Pafology/Fuck*. Morgenstein is caught off guard when “Stagg” comes off as less “Black” than he imagined he’d be but feels too uncomfortable to say so out loud.

Tamika Jones – Tamika Jones is a young Black mother whom Monk chats with in the waiting room of Lisa’s clinic. They start chatting about literature after Tamika overhears that Monk is a novelist. Tamika’s insight surprises Monk, and he feels ashamed to admit that he assumed, based on her appearance, that she would be stupid.

Van Go Jenkins – Van Go Jenkins—who typically goes by Go—is a young Black man who lives in poverty in Los Angeles. He is the protagonist of *My Pafology*, the novella Monk writes under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh as a satire of so-called “Black” fiction, and Go’s character is an exaggerated stereotype of the underprivileged Black characters typical of this genre. Though only 19 years old, he has already fathered four children by four different women. He is poor, has no work ethic, is angry at the world, and exists in an aimless cycle of drugs, guns, sex, and violence. Although Monk writes *My Pafology* to criticize elements of “Black” literature he deems lazy and offensive, ultimately Go’s character speaks to some of the conflicts that

plague Monk in his real life, like his oscillating love and resentment toward his parents and his struggle to find acceptance in society.

Penelope Dalton – Penelope Dalton is a character in *My Pafology*. She is the daughter of Mr. Dalton, a rich Black whom Go briefly works for. Penelope is the epitome of a spoiled rich kid—she spends her summer home from Stanford University lounging around the pool and getting drunk and high. She introduces herself to Go on his second day at work and orders him to drive her and her rich friend Roger around town. Although Penelope makes a show of caring about Go and the injustices he has faced as a young Black man who grew up poor, she ultimately belittles him and undermines his humanity, laughing at his stereotypical struggles. After driving Penelope and Roger around town all day, Go returns a drunk Penelope to her father’s pool house and rapes her, a crime Snookie Cane announces during Go’s appearance on her show.

Clareece Jenkins (Go’s Mother / Mama) – In *My Pafology*, Clareece Jenkins (“Mama”) is Van Go’s mother. A single mother, she struggles to provide her children with a good life despite their poverty. She worries that her son is headed down the wrong path and worries about his future. Mama and Baby Girl sit in the audience during Go’s appearance on the Snookie Cane Show. As Snookie Cane and the audience berate Go, Mama breaks down, crying that she raised Go to be better than this.

Cleona – In *My Pafology*, Cleona is a young woman whom Go has a child with. She and his other “baby mamas” confront Go on the Snookie Cane Show about Go’s failure to pay child support. Toward the beginning of the story, Go stops by Cleona’s house under the guise of wanting to see their child, Rexall. In fact, Go berates Cleona when she demands child support, and then he rapes her.

Snookie Cane – Snookie Cane, a talk show host, is a character in *My Pafology*. Monk seems to have loosely modeled her after real-life talk show host Kenya Dunston, on whose show Monk (as Stagg R. Leigh) appears later in *Eraseur*. In *My Pafology*, Snookie Cane tricks Go into appearing on a segment of her show in which the four mothers of Go’s four children confront him about his failure to pay child support.

Mr. Dalton – Mr. Dalton is a character in *My Pafology*. He is a wealthy Black man who Go briefly works for as a favor from Go’s mother’s friend Lois, who works as Mr. Dalton’s housekeeper. Mr. Dalton is based on a character of the same name from Richard Wright’s novel [Native Son](#), which *My Pafology* parodies. Mr. Dalton’s wealth amazes Go, who didn’t know a Black man could be so successful. However, Go ultimately turns on his employer, walking off the job after raping Dalton’s daughter Penelope.

Lois – In *My Pafology*, Lois is Mr. Dalton’s housekeeper. She’s a good friend of Mama and puts in a good word for Go to do work around Mr. Dalton’s house. She is protective of her friend

and warns Go not to mess things up—his mother is a good woman, and she doesn’t deserve everything Go puts her through.

Korean Man – The Korean man owns a convenience store in Los Angeles. Go claims the man wrongfully accused him of stealing. After Go gets his hands on a gun, he heads to the Korean man’s store with plans to rob him but ultimately ends up shooting and killing him, leading to a climactic police chase at the end of *My Pafology*.

Roger – In *My Pafology*, Roger is Penelope’s apparent friend or romantic partner. As Go drives Roger and Penelope around Los Angeles, the couple mocks Go for his poverty, belittling him and undermining his humanity even as they claim to respect him and his struggle. Notably, Roger and Penelope engage in much of the behavior that Go does—drinking, doing drugs, and being aimless—but their privilege allows them to skirt the consequences and keep their dignity and social standing intact.

Tom Wahzetepe – Tom Wahzetepe is a character in one of Monk’s short stories. In the story, he is invited to compete on a trivia game show alongside Hal Dullard, a white man from Indiana who is portrayed as being a good father and an upstanding member of his community. The game show is obviously rigged—while the host, Jack Spades, selects impossibly difficult questions for Tom to answer, he asks Dullard ridiculously easy ones. Despite Tom’s humble background and lack of a formal education, he answers all his questions correctly and is deemed the show’s winner—much to the anger and shock of Spades and the audience.

Jack Spades – Jack Spades is a character in one of Monk’s short stories. He hosts a trivia game show on which a white man (Hal Dullard) and Black man (Tom Wahzetepe) take turns answering trivia questions to determine the show’s new champion. However, the show is patently rigged. While Spades poses impossibly easy questions to Hall (who nevertheless fails to answer even one correctly), he asks Tom ridiculously complex, technical questions—and he is irate when Tom answers each one correctly and in great detail. It is only reluctantly and angrily that Spades announces Tom as the new winner.

Hal Dullard – Hal Dullard is a character in one of Monk’s short stories. He’s a white man and all-around upstanding citizen from Indiana who is also (as his name suggests) remarkably stupid. In the story, Hal and a Black man named Tom are contestants on a trivia game show, which is patently rigged. While the host, Jack Spades, asks Hal ridiculously simple questions, he poses complex, specific questions to Tom. Despite this disparity, Hal fails miserably, while Tom answers each question correctly and in great detail, enraging Spades.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Paula Baderman – Paula Baderman is a senior editor at Random House. Much to Monk’s horror, she and her colleagues

sing *My Pafology*'s praises, declaring the novel "magnificently raw and honest" and promising Monk (as Stagg R. Leigh) \$600,000 in advance payments for the manuscript.

Fiona – Fiona is a white woman whom Monk's father (Benjamin Ellison) had an affair with while serving overseas in Korea. Monk only learns of her existence—and that she and his father had a child together, Gretchen—when he stumbles upon some old love letters after moving back in with Mother.

Linda Mallory – Linda Mallory is a writer and professor whom Monk has had sex with in the past. She calls to solicit him for sex a few times throughout the book, though he usually turns her down.

Wilson Harnet – Wilson Harnet is the chair of the committee selected to judge the submissions for *The Book Award*. He wrote a book about his wife's cancer diagnosis. She ended up not dying, though, and divorced him for sharing all their secrets in his book.

Ailene Hoover – Ailene Hoover is an author who has published several critically acclaimed books. She serves on the committee selected to judge the submissions for *The Book Award*.

Thomas Tomad – Thomas Tomad is an author who serves on the committee selected to judge the submissions for *The Book Award*. He is also an editor at a publishing house that specializes in the books of incarcerated people serving life sentences.

Jon Paul Sigmarsen – Jon Paul Sigmarsen is an author who hosts a PBS show in Minnesota. He serves on the committee selected to judge the submissions for *The Book Award*.

Davis Gimbel – Davis Gimbel is a writer who attends the conference alongside Monk. He detests Monk and heckles him after Monk finishes his reading at a conference they both attend, declaring Monk a "mimetic hack."

Cynthia – Cynthia is Wiley Morgenstein's "assistant," though when Monk (as Stagg R. Leigh) meets with them to discuss plans for a film adaptation of *My Pafology/Fuck*, Monk insinuates that she is more likely Morgenstein's mistress.

The Skinhead – The skinhead is a relative of Fiona and her daughter Gretchen. He directs Monk to Gretchen's home—but only after Monk offers to pay him.

Clevon – Clevon is a man Marilyn used to date. The couple is in the process of breaking up when Monk enters Marilyn's life.

Yvonne – Yvonne is a receptionist at Lisa's clinic in Washington, D.C.

Willy the Wonker – In *My Pafology*, Willy the Wonker (alternatively called "Willy the wino") is a disheveled alcoholic who roams the streets and antagonizes Go, making crass remarks about Go's mother and insinuating that he is Go's father. He alternatively belittles Go and urges him to be better.

Tyrell/Jeep – In *My Pafology*, Tyrell is a "pretty," rich Black guy whom Cleona is seeing. Go also refers to him derisively as

"Jeep" (paired with a racial slur), referencing the vehicle he drives. Go gets into several altercations with Jeep throughout *My Pafology*.

Yellow – Yellow is one of Go's friends in *My Pafology*. He and Go repeatedly get into inane arguments that typically end with each shouting expletives back and forth at the other.

Tito – Tito is one of Go's friends in *My Pafology*. He runs with a rough crowd, and Mama, worried about her son, warns Go to stop spending time with him.

Sharinda – In *My Pafology*, Sharinda is a woman with whom Go has a child. She and his other "baby mamas" confront Go on Snookie Cane's show about Go's failure to pay child support.

Robertarina – In *My Pafology*, Robertarina is a woman whom Go has a child with. She and his other "baby mamas" confront Go on *The Snookie Cane Show* about Go's failure to pay child support.

Reynisha – In *My Pafology*, Reynisha is a woman whom Go has a child with. She and his other "baby mamas" confront Go on *The Snookie Cane Show* about Go's failure to pay child support.

Tardreece/Baby Girl – Tardreece is Van Go Jenkins's sister in *My Pafology*.

Rexall – In *My Pafology*, Rexall is Van Go's child with Cleona. He has (as Go calls it) "Down sinder" (Downs syndrome).



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



RACE AND IDENTITY

At the core of *Erasure* is Thelonious "Monk" Ellison's struggle to reconcile his own sense of self with the identity that society projects onto him.

Monk opens *Erasure*, which takes the form of his personal diary, with the provocative declaration that he does not "believe in race." While he recognizes that his dark complexion, his curly hair, and the fact that some of his ancestors were enslaved makes him Black in a strictly technical sense, he insists that he does not fit the mold of Black American life as it appears according to common stereotypes. Monk was not, for instance, raised in the inner city or deep south, and he isn't all that great at basketball. Meanwhile, he graduated summa cum laude from Harvard and enjoys listening to Mahler on vinyl. While Monk acknowledges that there are indeed bigots out there who wish to harm him due to the color of his skin, he maintains that this only means he is "black" by society's standards—it has no

bearing on how he conceives of himself. As the story unfolds, however, Monk increasingly finds himself in situations that call into question whether it's possible to separate one's own racial identity from race as a social construct. If social norms regarding race affect him in his daily life, doesn't that influence his sense of self to some degree?

Indeed, as the story unfolds, the reader learns that outside forces have influenced Monk's understanding of race more heavily than he would care to admit even to himself. Monk's late father, a doctor, was the son of a high-achieving, respectable Black doctor, and he made sure that his children strove for that same, stereotype-defying standard of excellence. Although Monk's father's high standards resulted in his children all attaining a high level of success in their chosen fields, it also instilled in Monk a deep sense of internalized racism that Monk returns to throughout his adult life, causing him to make stereotypical assumptions about and harshly judge poor Black people in the same way that bigoted white people might judge Monk. The novel thus raises the question of whether race (and one's understanding of race) can exist independent of society, or if social norms, culture, stereotypes, and one's upbringing necessarily play a role in race and racial identity. Ultimately, Monk's pervasive struggle to accept how deeply race has affected his life and his sense of self points to the latter.



FAMILIAL OBLIGATION VS. PERSONAL NEEDS

Erasure begins with Monk's return to his hometown in Washington, D.C. for a literature conference. At first, he intends only to drop by and say hello to his family, whom he hasn't seen in a while and with whom he isn't terribly close. But after his sister Lisa unexpectedly dies and Mother's early signs of Alzheimer's become too acute and frightening to ignore, Monk decides to put his life in California on hold to move back in with his mother and her longtime housekeeper, Lorraine, and assume responsibility for his mother's finances and care. As Monk spends more time at home, he learns new information about his childhood that forces him to question previously unexamined ideas about his family and their history together. An old box of Father's personal papers, for instance, reveals evidence of his father's affair and the resultant child, revelations that challenge the reverence with which Monk once regarded his father.

Monk is also reunited with his brother Bill, whom he hasn't spoken to in years. Bill has recently been outed as gay, and as he struggles to cope with the pain of his new estrangement from his wife and children, he also takes advantage of his new freedom to be out and honest about his identity as an openly gay man. Bill's overt expression of his sexuality rattles Monk, and although he makes several comments that might be considered homophobic, ultimately his real issue with Bill isn't

Bill's homosexuality, but rather his newfound freedom to prioritize his own desires and self-expression above his obligations to others. Monk himself has many questions about his own identity and what he owes to his loved ones, yet his guilt-derived obligation to be there for his family (to make up for all the years he was not) forces him to put his own desires on the back burner.

While *Erasure* doesn't answer all the questions it raises about how much we owe family, and whether it is selfish or necessary to put one's own needs and desires above one's familial obligations, the novel casts an insightful eye on the complex dynamics of family life. And as Monk turns a more critical, discerning eye toward his past, he finds himself forced to ask difficult questions about how significantly his upbringing and family shaped the person he is today—for better or for worse—and what he owes his family because of (or despite) that influence.



ARTISTIC INTEGRITY VS. COMMERCIAL SUCCESS

Monk—sometimes to an insufferable extent—considers his own literary talent far superior to writers like Juanita Mae Jenkins, who in Monk's mind shamelessly churn out novels that cater to whatever reductive rendering of the human experience the mass culture demands at a given moment in history. Jenkins's bestselling novel *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* offends Monk's sensibilities not only because he finds the exaggerated African American vernacular in which it is written offensive, but also because he believes Jenkins herself does not believe that her book possesses the artistic merit and social import the publishing industry and the mass culture it serves attaches to it. Instead, she has delivered the "raw, real" depiction of Black oppression that her guilt-ridden, white, liberal audience claims to want, prioritizing fame, a hefty paycheck, and the comfort of her white, guilt-ridden liberal readership above her own artistic integrity. In short, she is a sell-out. Meanwhile the serious novels Monk prefers to write—intentionally complex reimaginations of ancient Greek dramas—hardly make any money (if a publisher picks them up at all).

To make a point about the publishing industry's troubling pattern of pigeonholing Black authors, Monk pens *My Pafology*, a parody of the "urban literature" style of writing that *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* exemplifies. But when—to Monk's horror—the publishing industry fails to recognize *My Pafology* as the parody Monk intended it to be, he acts with the same lack of integrity for which he criticizes Juanita Mae Jenkins. Indeed, as Jenkins did before him, Monk easily (if shamefully) accepts the \$600,000 advance the publishing house has offered him and the \$3 million a Hollywood producer pays for the film rights. Although Monk remains uneasy and personally offended by the obscene amount of money these powerful institutions offer

him for what he considers pure dreck, ultimately he plays into it nonetheless, realizing, perhaps, that in order to put himself in a position to make the art he actually cares about, he must first attain adequate financial means—no matter how low he must stoop to do so.



AUTHENTICITY

Erasure is predominantly a searing satire on the American publishing industry and the veneer of so-called “political correctness.” In a broader sense,

though, the novel asks important questions about what it means to live an authentic life. In writing and publishing *My Pafology* (a parody of the genre of so-called “Black” literature that over-relies on exaggerated slang and tired stereotypes) and eventually playing the part of the book’s imaginary author (Stagg R. Leigh, a recently released convict imprisoned for murder), Monk not only becomes one of the disingenuous, affected sell-outs he so despises, but he also fails to honestly examine *why* this style writing so upsets him, why he prefers instead to write novels that are intentionally opaque and incomprehensible, and what all this says about Monk himself.

Readers of *Erasure* will quickly note that beneath the outrageously exaggerated African American vernacular and cynically grim and stereotypical plot of *My Pafology*, the central conflicts of the book-within-a-book clearly reflect the conflicts that plague Monk in his real life: his mixed feelings of love and resentment toward Mother, his unrealized anger at Father, and his anger at a mainstream culture whose proclaimed efforts to empower African Americans invariably result in yet more exploitation.

Monk’s refusal to place his name on the work further points to his lack of authenticity—that is, to his refusal to confront and own the real feelings that cause him to feel such anger at the type of literature *My Pafology* parodies and the cultural attitudes that beget it. Creating and becoming the alter-ego of Stagg Leigh thus becomes a crutch Monk turns to to avoid addressing or even admitting to his own hang-ups about race, identity, and self-knowledge. In this sense, then, Monk is no more authentic—and indeed, perhaps less authentic—than the very authors whose phony, stereotype-laden works he sought to parody in the first place. For as unimaginative and reductive as Monk deems Juanita Mae Jenkins’s writing, she at least has the courage and honesty to stand behind her work and the ideas it interrogates. Monk, on the other hand, turns to parody and criticism to shield others—and more crucially, Monk himself—from his authentic self and genuinely felt concerns. In this way, then, *Erasure* examines the complex relationship between self-expression and self-knowledge. The novel points to the paradoxical notion that sometimes the airs a person puts on end up revealing hidden truths, whereas supposed attempts at authenticity end up being disingenuous and contrived.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



WOODWORKING

In *Erasure*, woodworking, a hobby of Monk’s, symbolizes the certainty and clarity Monk desires—and yet so infrequently achieves—in his professional pursuits, his relationships, and his sense of self. As a writer, Monk is used to the slippery, fluid quality of written and spoken language, which can strike a person differently based on a number of factors, from circumstance, to experience, to expectations. The same language that creates a feeling of unity among some people can alienate others. For instance, Monk recalls the intense “awkwardness” he felt as a child when he struggled to use African American vernacular in a way that felt and sounded natural.

Woodworking, by contrast, is about concrete surfaces—and because of this, there is considerably less room for interpretation, misinterpretation, and error. “Damnit, a table was a table was a table,” Monk declares at one point in the novel, describing the clear and unambiguous final result of any given woodworking project. But the same cannot be said for Monk’s novels, which rarely receive the feedback Monk desires. Publishers disregard Monk’s serious novels for their failure to reflect consciously on race—a genre convention the publishing industry more or less requires of the works by Black writers it deigns to publish at all. Meanwhile *My Pafology*, the caustic work of satire Monk pens as an attack on the publishing industry, is grossly misinterpreted, with publishers and critics alike failing to grasp its unserious tone and instead interpreting as a genuine representation of Black life, and then using that interpretation to reaffirm their own assumptions and prejudices about Black people and race as a whole. For Monk, woodworking functions as a necessary escape from the burdensome, frustrating, and sometimes painful situations that tend to arise once fluid, finicky language is involved.



FISHING

Much like woodworking, fishing symbolizes the certainty and clarity that Monk craves in his personal and professional life. Fly fishing is another of Monk’s favorite hobbies, and he is drawn to it the same reason he is drawn to woodworking: both hobbies offer the allure of certainty he so rarely sees in his relationships or in his work as a writer, where words and ideas are subject to interpretation, and each social interaction or writing project leaves him vulnerable to being misunderstood or misrepresented. The main plot of *Erasure* is interspersed with brief interludes in

which Monk describes some aspect of fishing that entices him, and these sections function to juxtapose the clarity and certainty that Monk so desires with the confusion and ambiguity he is more often faced with in his writing pursuits and in his personal relationships. “Generally fish prefer the smooth curves of nature to the hard edges of humans,” Monk notes in one such interlude, referring to the error some people make in placing humanmade objects in a stream to try to “improve” the fishes’ habitat. In fact, such additions can “cause more harm than good.” In using the figurative language of fishing to contrast the “smooth curves of nature” with the “hard edges of humans,” Monk comments more generally on the ease and assurance with which different organisms coexist with the unnatural, inefficient, and fallible methods humans have created to interact with and understand one another.

for an idea that Monk will return to throughout the novel: how the broader world invariably shapes and informs one’s sense of self. Although Monk himself might not “believe in race,” he is nevertheless affected by people who do believe in it and act accordingly, seeing his “brown skin, curly hair, [and] wide nose” as an invitation to marginalize or otherwise harm him.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞ “Have you gone to college?” I asked.

The girl laughed.

“Don’t laugh,” I said. “I think you’re really smart. You should at least try.”

“I didn’t even finish high school.”

I didn’t know what to say to that. I scratched my head and looked at the other faces in the room. I felt an inch tall because I had expected this young woman with the blue fingernails to be a certain way, to be slow and stupid, but she was neither. I was the stupid one.

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison, Tamika Jones (speaker), Lisa, Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

This is a conversation Monk has with a young Black woman he meets in the lobby of Lisa’s clinic while waiting for Lisa to finish with her work for the day (Lisa is an OBGYN who runs a clinic that caters to predominantly Black, underprivileged women and girls). Overhearing that Monk is an author, the young woman (whom Lisa later refers to as Tamika) asks Monk what sort of books he writes before sharing some of the novels she’s recently read and enjoyed. As they talk, Monk inwardly admonishes himself for having initially judged the woman to be stupid and uneducated based on her appearance and circumstances—he assumed that because she is a young and seemingly poor Black mother, that she would also be uncultured, uneducated, and uncurious about the world. But when the woman comments intelligently and thoughtfully about a work of serious literature she recently read, Monk realizes how wrong he was—and he feels ashamed for it, realizing that he, not Tamika, “was the stupid one” in their interaction.

This passage is important because it hints at the internalized racism that has engrained itself in Monk, due in



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Graywolf Press edition of *Erasure* published in 2011.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ The hard, *gritty* truth of the matter is that I hardly ever think about race. Those times when I did think about it a lot I did so because of my guilt for not thinking about it. I don’t believe in race. I believe there are people who will shoot me or hang me or cheat me and try to stop me because they do believe in race, because of my brown skin, curly hair, wide nose and slave ancestors. But that’s just the way it is.

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 2

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the opening chapter of *Erasure*, which takes the form of a series of extended diary entries and personal reflections written by its narrator and protagonist, the author Thelonious “Monk” Ellison. In his opening remarks, Monk introduces himself to readers and lays out his ideas about race, which will become a central focus of Monk’s story as he struggles to support himself as a writer without compromising on his artistic integrity. In particular, he struggles to find success with his books because they do not grapple explicitly with race and racial identity, which the publishing industry has decided is necessary for works written by Black authors. In particular Monk’s personal ideas about race—and how they differ from those of the publishing industry—lays the groundwork

large part to his late father's impossibly high standards and Monk's unceasing desire to impress his father. Monk, it becomes increasingly clear, has developed his own ideas about artistry and greatness based on his father's, and these high standards have caused him to look down on Black struggle and perpetuate the negative stereotypes that mainstream society attaches to Black people.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☛ For my father, the road had to wind uphill both ways and be as difficult as possible. Sadly, this was the sensibility he instilled in me when I set myself to the task of writing fiction. It wasn't until I brought him a story that was purposely confusing and obfuscating that he seemed at all impressed and pleased. He said, smiling, "You made me work, son."

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Father

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 32

Explanation and Analysis

Monk weaves his reflections on childhood memories through the main plot of *Erasure*, as in the above passage, in which Monk meditates on how his drive to impress his father influenced his artistic sensibilities. Monk, as an author, is known for writing novels that are complex and opaque in style and substance, and this passage makes clear that Monk's penchant for this style of writing comes from his father, for whom any endeavor in life "had to wind uphill both ways and be as difficult as possible" for it to be considered worthwhile. Grasping his father's high expectations and desperate for the man's approval, young Monk wrote "a story that was purposely confusing and obfuscating," finally earning his father's approval.

This passage points to how Monk's artistic sensibilities—and the persona he constructs around those sensibilities—are less a reflection of his authentic self and more the effects of his unceasing longing for his father's approval. This, in turn, points to the book's broader focus on what it means to be authentic, and the sometimes negative (but ultimately unavoidable) ways in which the wider world—whether that means the people one interacts with in one's daily life, or society at large—help to shape a person's sense of self.

Chapter 5 Quotes

☛ "The line is, you're not black enough," my agent said. "What's that mean, Yul? How do they even know I'm black? Why does it matter?" "We've been over this before. They know because of the photo on your first book. They know because they've seen you. They know because you're black, for crying out loud." "What, do I have to have my characters comb their afros and be called niggers for these people?" "It wouldn't hurt." I was stunned into silence.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison, Yul (speaker), Stagg R. Leigh

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 43

Explanation and Analysis

This is a phone conversation between Monk and his editor, Yul, in response to Monk's latest rejection by a publishing house. "The line is, you're not black enough," Yul offers in explanation. Essentially—and as Monk clarifies with blunt, unflinching language—Yul is saying that Monk's novels don't adhere to the industry's narrow definition of the sort of books Black authors are supposed to write. In their eyes, Black authors aren't allowed to separate their racial identity from their work—their art must always speak directly to the experience of being Black, and that experience itself must affirm the stereotypes the mainstream culture has decided are synonymous with Black life in America (characters who "comb their afros" and call one another "niggers," as Monk so harshly puts it).

Monk, whose specialty is complex reworkings of ancient Greek dramas, struggles to achieve success with an industry that refuses to see him as an author independent of his race. Monk resents Yul's blunt advice that it "wouldn't hurt" to write a book that embraces the conventions of so-called "Black" literature, and it's this resentment that leads to his angrily penning the novella *My Pafology* under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh.

☛ Poor me! A man without a religion, without a decent lie to call my own. Giving up life for life, loving as I knew I should, and, perhaps most importantly, attempting to live up to the measure of my sister. Time seemed anything but mine, as if I were sleeping, walking and eating with a stopwatch!

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker), Mother, Lisa

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 51

Explanation and Analysis

These are Monk’s inner thoughts as he contemplates moving home to take care of Mother in the aftermath of Lisa’s sudden, unexpected death.

Notably, Monk laments how his irreligious status leaves him “without a decent lie to call [his] own,” framing faith in a god or afterlife as wishful thinking people use to find reason for tragedy and suffering of the sort that Monk has just experienced, and to motivate them to act selflessly in the name of good rather than to fulfill their own needs and desires. This points to the novel’s broader focus on the dueling priorities of familial obligation and personal needs. Throughout the book, Monk will struggle to balance his own desire for personal and professional fulfillment with his obligation to support his mother and honor the legacy of his father.

Monk’s word choice here is also important when he describes religion as a “lie.” In addition to figuratively expressing Monk’s apparent atheism, the phrase also foreshadows—and gives explanation for—Monk’s choice to pen *My Pafology*, which happens in the following chapter. *My Pafology* is a lie both because Monk pens it under a pseudonym, and also because its content and style directly oppose Monk’s artistic sensibilities and features a representation of Black life he feels is reductive, inaccurate, and offensive. Soon, Monk will have “a lie to call [his] own,” it will just take a different form from the “lie” Monk outlines in the above passage.

Lastly, Monk’s effusive resolve to take action and start fulfilling his obligation to his family before time runs out speaks to his state of mind at this point in the story. It’s clear that Monk’s professional life has left him unfulfilled, and Lisa’s sudden death has reminded him that life is short and never guaranteed. For these reasons, he feels great urgency to live his life in a manner he feels proud of, and moving home to care for Mother is a way he can do that.

Chapter 6 Quotes

“I went to what had been my father’s study, and perhaps still was his study, but now it was where I worked. I sat and stared at Juanita Mae Jenkins’ face on *Time* magazine. [...] I remembered passages of *Native Son* and *The Color Purple* and *Amos and Andy* and my hands began to shake, the world opening around me, tree roots trembling on the ground outside, people in the street shouting *dint*, *ax*, *fo*, *screet* and *fahvre!* and I was screaming inside, complaining that I didn’t sound like that, that my mother didn’t sound like that, that my father didn’t sound like that and I imagined myself sitting on a park bench counting the knives in my switchblade collection and a man came up to me and he asked me what I was doing and my mouth opened and I couldn’t help what came out, ‘Why fo you be axin?’”

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker), Mother, Lisa, Father, Juanita Mae Jenkins

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 61-62

Explanation and Analysis

After Lisa’s death, Monk moves home to take over her role as Mother’s primary caregiver amid Mother’s declining health. Following yet another publisher’s rejection of his latest novel, Monk’s mounting personal, financial, and artistic woes overwhelm him, and his anger and frustration culminates in his frantic, impassioned writing of *My Pafology*, the satire on urban fiction that comprises the following 10 chapters of *Eraseur*. Notably, Monk writes the novella in his father’s study, a setting that adds to his frustrated, angry mood. Little by little, the reader learns more of the extent to which Monk’s desire to impress his father’s unreasonably high standards has shaped Monk as a person and as an artist. As an adult, Monk is frustrated to find that the intentionally complex, intellectually rigorous writing style he has honed to please his late father fails to impress the publishing industry, which prefers to publish Black writers like Juanita Mae Jenkins, whose novels draw from stereotypes mainstream culture attaches to Black people. Monk, taking after his father, finds this type of writing diminutive and offensive, and he resents having to write in a style just because he’s Black, feeling it compromises his integrity as an artist and as a Black person.

In this moment, all Monk’s anger and frustration bubbles over, and he imagines himself as the angry, young Black protagonists featured in seminal works of urban fiction, like *Native Son*: “I imagined myself sitting on a park bench counting the knives in my switchblade collection and a man

came up to me and he asked me what I was doing and my mouth opened and I couldn't help what came out, 'Why fo you be axin?'" *My Pafology* is Monk's answer to this question. On the one hand, the novella contains humorously exaggerated tropes and archetypes common to the genre of urban fiction and functions as something of a complex, longform joke on Monk's part—an overwrought piece of writing designed to point out everything that's wrong with the publishing industry's troubling pattern of reducing Black authors down to a singular experience. On the other hand, though, this scene emphasizes how the novella is also a true expression of the rage and frustration that Monk genuinely feels. This complicates Monk's developing relationship to the novella as it (shockingly to Monk) ends up being unanimously praised by critics and audiences alike, for he can't dismiss the work as entirely ironic or untrue.

My Pafology: Won Quotes

☛ I look at my hands and they all covered wif blood and I realize I don't know what goin on. So, I stab Mama again. I stab her cause I scared. I stab Mama cause I love her. I stab Mama cause I hate her. Cause I love her. Cause I hate her. Cause I ain't got no daddy. Then I walk out the kitchen and stand outside, leavin Mama crawlin round on the linolum tryin to hold in her guts. I stands out on the sidewalk just drippin blood like a muthafucka. I look up at the sky and I try to see Jesus, but I cain't.

Related Characters: Van Go Jenkins (speaker), Thelonious "Monk" Ellison, Stagg R. Leigh, Clareece Jenkins (Go's Mother / Mama)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 65

Explanation and Analysis

This is an excerpt from the opening chapter of *My Pafology*, a novella Monk writes under the name Stagg R. Leigh. *My Pafology* satirizes works of urban fiction, which take place in a city and represent the struggles of the people who live there. Most works of recent and contemporary urban fiction (and the type that Monk satirizes in his novella) focus on Black people and rely on lazy stereotypes and reductive tropes to dramatize their struggles. The protagonist of *My Pafology*, Van Go Jenkins, displays a number of stereotypes attached to characters of the genre. He is a young Black man who was raised in poverty by a single mother and whose father is not in the picture. Go is embittered, aimless, and morally compromised. Although he forgoes standard

English and displays a lack of formal education in his writing and speech, his thoughts are occasionally poignant, insightful, and revealing. This opening passage outlines a number of these traits, cluing in readers to the novella's satirical tone (though ultimately, to Monk's shock and disgust, publishers take the book seriously and fail to see it as satire).

Although Monk writes *My Pafology* as a cynical exercise to get out some of his anger at the publishing industry, it is not totally devoid of authenticity. Notably, Van Go's strongly conflicting feelings toward Mama (I stab Mama cause I love her. I stab Mama cause I hate her. Cause I love her. Cause I hate her") mirror Monk's real life. At the time he writes the novella, he has just moved back home to take care of Mother, who is experiencing serious cognitive decline. Although Monk honors his familial obligation to care for his mother in his old age, it's a thankless and stressful job, and he can't help but feel relief when he is finally able to transfer her to a care facility. In a sense, then, Monk both loves and hates Mother much in the same way Go loves and hates Mama.

My Pafology: Too Quotes

☛ "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "Fuck you," I say.
 "Fuck you," Yellow say.
 "You ain't shit," I say.
 "Well, you is shit," Yellow say.

Related Characters: Van Go Jenkins, Yellow (speaker), Thelonious "Monk" Ellison, Stagg R. Leigh, Juanita Mae

Jenkins

Related Themes:   **Page Number:** 75-76**Explanation and Analysis**

In *My Pafology*, this is an argument that ensues between Van Go and his friend Yellow after one insults the other's mother. The language is crass and humorously repetitive, with the characters lashing out with the same insult back and forth and not ultimately getting anywhere in their argument. This passage exemplifies the lack of character development and ineffective use of language that Monk employs in *My Pafology*, the novella he authors under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh. *My Pafology* is Monk's expression of the anger and frustration he feels at the publishing industry's troubling preference for works of "urban fiction," which *My Pafology* satirizes, and which Monk considers offensive due to the genre's reductive representation of Black life in America. The above passage's pointless, needlessly crass, and frankly stupid dialogue is characteristic of the book as a whole, and Monk intends for such dialogue to lay bare the offensive and overly simplistic manner in which authors of urban fiction (like Juanita Mae Jenkins) write Black characters.

Later, when publishers and Hollywood producers alike express unanimous praise for *My Pafology*—despite its containing egregiously awful writing as seen in the above passage—it reaffirms Monk's conviction that the publishing industry perpetuates racist stereotypes while pretending to care about giving voice to the Black experience and elevating Black artists.

My Pafology: Sex Quotes

☝ “You live around here, Van?” Roger asked. “What is this? Compton?”

I don't say nothin. I just glance at them in the mirror. They starin out the windows like we in Jungleground or some shit. Like we at Dissyland in that fuckin submarine. Niggers on the street be lookin at me drivin this fine car and I feels cool till I remember that I'm in the front by myself and them two bitches be in the back and I be lookin like some flunky-ass chauffeur.

Related Characters: Van Go Jenkins, Roger (speaker), Penelope Dalton, Mr. Dalton**Related Themes:**   **Page Number:** 103**Explanation and Analysis**

In this scene from *My Pafology*, Van Go drives around Penelope—the college-age daughter of his wealthy employer, Mr. Dalton—and Roger, Penelope's wealthy friend. Go's wealthy passengers have ordered him to take them to his neighborhood so they can see where he lives, and Go has no choice but to oblige. Although Penelope initially shows concern for Go, asking whether her father is paying him enough and making sweeping, empathetic statements about his plight as a disadvantaged young Black man, her later statements and the behavior she and Roger exhibit here show that she is more amused by than concerned with Go, treating the excursion to the run-down neighborhood where Go lives less as a chance to understand him better and more as a dangerous but exciting fieldtrip. (“They starin out the windows like we in Jungleground or some sit. Like we at Dissyland in that fuckin submarine.”)

Monk writes *My Pafology* to express his frustration at the publishing industry, which publicly pronounces its mission to provide a platform for Black writers and give voice to Black experiences, but which ultimately only publishes books that reduce those experiences to a series of tired, lazy stereotypes and reductive tropes of Black struggle. In so doing, they perpetuate negative stereotypes of Black people and provide readers with the opportunity to gape morbidly at the Black suffering they claim to stand in solidarity with—just as Penelope and Roger are doing in this scene.

My Pafology: Ate Quotes

☝ I can feel the rage swell up inside me. I hates this man. I hates my mama. I hates myself. I'm seein my face in his. I see the ape that stupid girls say they be fraid of. [...] I see Mama bleedin in my dream. I see my babies. I see Rexall, wifout a brain, growin up and axing “Why not me?” I see my daddy. I see myself. I shoot the muthafucka. Pop! In the gut.

Willy double over and he look at me like to say, “Why?” I yell at him. I be standin over him yellin at the back of his head. “Cause you aint shit!” I say. “Cause you made me, muthafucka! Cause I aint shit!” I be cryin now and I think I hear sumpin out at the street. I run again.

Related Characters: Van Go Jenkins, Willy the Wonker (speaker), Thelonious “Monk” Ellison, Stagg R. Leigh, Clareece Jenkins (Go's Mother / Mama)**Related Themes:**    

Page Number: 124**Explanation and Analysis**

Go is hiding out in (what he thinks is) an abandoned building after shooting the Korean convenience store owner in a robbery gone wrong and fleeing the scene. But Willy the Wonker, an alcoholic man who repeatedly antagonizes and belittles Go with his insinuations that he is in fact Go's father, appears before Go and proceeds to belittle him as he has done throughout the novel. At this point, Go's patience has expired. He looks in Willy's face and sees himself, and in that resemblance he also sees all that hatred and condescension that he has for Willy and that society has for them both. In that moment, Go impulsively shoots and kills Willy. When Willy asks why Go did this, Go replies, "Cause you aint shit! [...] Cause you made me, muthafucka! Cause I aint shit!" Go's explanation, characteristic of the on-the-nose, exaggerated prose that *My Pafology* uses to satirize conventional works of urban fiction, juxtaposes a moment of melodramatic revelation with overly simple prose, essentially diminishing Go's experience with his inability to articulate it.

But for as intentionally reductive and offensive as Monk intends *My Pafology* to be, bits of poignant truth about Monk's own life and inner struggle manage to sneak their way into the writing, too. Here, notably, Go's anger at his potential father, Willy, parallels Monk's slowly developing resentment toward his own father, who greatly shaped Monk's identity and artistic sensibilities yet was also stern and emotionally withholding. Whether consciously or unconsciously, Monk seems to use *My Pafology* to indirectly express some of the anger he remains unable to unwilling to feel about his father directly.

These are the closing lines of *My Pafology*, Monk's satire on urban fiction. The police are hot on Go's trail after the release of security footage that shows him shooting and killing a Korean man who owns a convenience store. Go tries to force the police to give him a new car by holding a girl he snatches from a post office as hostage, the car's airbags go off before he can flee the scene, and he finds himself in police custody. Realizing that he's at the end of the line with nowhere else to turn, he faces the cameras pointed at him. With a tone of mixed bemusement and resignation, he says, "Hey, Mama. [...] Hey. Baby Girl. Look at me. I on TV." On the surface, Go's remark points to how society limits the success that Black people can achieve in America. Committing a crime is the best chance a Black man from an impoverished background stands of getting on TV, the novel clumsily argues.

In *My Pafology*, which satirizes the reductive sociocultural criticism and offensive tropes and racial stereotypes of urban fiction, Go's words implicitly point to the limited means through which Black writers can gain mainstream audiences for their writing—can be on TV, so to speak. They can write works of urban fiction, like Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives In Da Ghetto*, which rely on lazy stereotypes and America's morbid fascination with Black people's trauma to gain the attention of publishers and readers. But they cannot write the books Monk himself prefers to write—complicated works that have nothing to do with race. Black authors and artists, *My Pafology* implicitly suggests, have a far narrower opportunity to get "on TV," so to speak, compared to white authors, whom the publishing industry doesn't limit in the same way.

Notably, the end of *My Pafology* parallels the end of *Erasure*, which sees Monk take the stage to accept *The Book Award* for *My Pafology* (which by this point has been retitled *Fuck*). As he does so, he looks into the camera as Van Go does here and proclaims, "Egads, I'm on television." In this way, Monk's real experiences prove true the criticisms he raises in *My Pafology/Fuck*, with systemic racism bringing about both characters' fates. Just as society limits Go's opportunities for success to the point that he can only appear on TV as a criminal, society limits Monk's opportunities to succeed as a Black author. He receives his first major award for a work that upholds the tired tropes and offensive stereotypes of Black people that the publishing industry (and society at large) wishes to uphold, not for the rigorous, complex novels he is actually proud of.

My Pafology: Tin Quotes

💡 I looks up and see the cameras. I get kicked again while I'm bein pulled to my feet. But I dont care. The cameras is pointin at me. I be on the TV. The cameras be full of me. I on TV. I say, "Hey, Mama." I say, "Hey, Baby Girl. Look at me. I on TV."

Related Characters: Van Go Jenkins (speaker), Thelonious "Monk" Ellison, Stagg R. Leigh, Clareece Jenkins (Go's Mother / Mama), Korean Man, Tardreece/Baby Girl

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 131**Explanation and Analysis**

Chapter 7 Quotes

☞ “I want you to meet him.” And suddenly Bill’s voice was different, but it was more than just the sound of a man in love. His pronunciation changed. It was not quite that he developed a stereotypical lisp, but it was close.

“Why are you talking like that?”

His voice went back to normal. “Like what?”

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison, Bill (speaker), Mother, Father

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 135

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is from a phone conversation between Monk and Bill. Monk knows he has to move Mother to a care facility soon, and he calls Bill to ask if he can help pay for it (this is before *My Pafology* is picked by a major publishing house). But Bill is in the middle of an acrimonious divorce after his ex-wife found out about his homosexuality and tells Monk he isn’t in a position to help Monk. After this, Bill changes the subject and tells Monk he wants him to meet his new lover. Monk immediately notes a difference in Bill’s voice, describing it as “more than just the sound of a man in love. His pronunciation changed. It was not quite that he developed a stereotypical lisp, but it was close.” Monk, rather than responding with openness to what seems like Bill’s genuine attempt to let Monk into his life and close some of the distance that has developed between them in adulthood, replies with a passive-aggressive jab at the “stereotypical lisp” he claims to detect in Bill’s voice. He asks Bill, “Why are you talking like that?” a cruel question that Bill either fails to understand or chooses to overlook.

On the one hand, Monk’s critical observation about Bill’s apparent lisp could hint at his possible homophobia. Ultimately, however, it is more crucially a sign of the jealousy that Bill’s embrace of his authentic self brings out in Monk, who struggles to make sense of who he is independent of the persona he constructed over the years to earn his father’s approval, and the persona he must assume as an author if he wishes to see fame as a writer. Monk is jealous of Bill’s courage to be himself, even in the face of rejection and struggle—something Monk himself struggles to do throughout the novel, and especially after *My Pafology* receives unanimous praise from publishers, critics, and audiences alike.

☞ The news of the money came and I breathed an ironic and bitter sigh of relief. Maybe I felt a bit of vindication somewhere inside me. Certainly, I felt a great deal of hostility toward an industry so eager to seek out and sell such demeaning and soul-destroying drivel.

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker), Stagg R. Leigh, Mother

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 137

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Monk describes his reaction to hearing the amount of the advance he will receive for *My Pafology*, the satirical novella he submitted under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh. Monk is ashamed of the “soul-destroying drivel” he considers *My Pafology* to be—he wrote it as a work of performance art (or so he tells himself) to antagonize and call out the publishing industry for publishing works of stereotype-laden urban fiction that he deems intellectually insulting and offensive to Black people. Although he is disturbed when the industry fails to recognize *My Pafology* for the satire Monk intended it to be, the promise of a high payout softens the blow, especially given the financial strain he is under now that the responsibility for funding Mother’s care falls to him.

This passage puts Monk’s confused and conflicting attitude toward *My Pafology* and the publishing industry as a whole on display. He claims to feel “a bit of vindication” at the news that he will be paid for writing the offensive nonsense he considers *My Pafology* to be, insinuating that his payout is proof that he has somehow gamed the system, leeching money off an industry he despises for its “eager[ness] to seek out and sell such demeaning and soul-destroying drivel.” Although this is somewhat true, Monk fails to acknowledge his direct participation in this system, providing the very “demeaning and soul-destroying drivel” that helps the system to thrive. At the same time, he is not in a position not to work, and so his participation in this system, however limiting and discriminatory toward Black authors it may be, enables him to continue making the art he actually wants to make. Within this flawed and unjust system, Monk cannot have his cake and eat it too: he can either refuse to yield to the demands the publishing industry forces on him as a Black artist and fail to generate enough wealth to practice his art, or he can give in to the system and write the “drivel” that sells—but abandon his artistic and moral integrity in the process.

☛ I tried to distance myself from the position where the newly sold piece-of-shit novel had placed me vis-à-vis my art. It was not exactly the case that I had sold out, but I was not, apparently, going to turn away the check. I considered my woodworking and why I did it. In my writing my instinct was to defy form, but I very much sought in defying it to affirm it, an irony that was difficult enough to articulate, much less defend. But the wood, the feel of it, the smell of it, the weight of it. It was so much more real than words. The wood was so simple. Damnit, a table was a table was a table.

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker), Stagg R. Leigh

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 139

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Monk reflects on the recent sale of *My Pafology*, a satirical novella he wrote as a scathing critique on the publishing industry and assumed no one would take seriously. To his shock, not only have publishers failed to see the novella as the joke Monk intended it to be, but they are also huge fans of it—and jump at the opportunity to publish it. Unsure of what to think of this shocking (and disturbing) development and what it means in terms of Monk’s artistic integrity, Monk takes a step back and compares the situation to his hobby of woodworking. In the novel, woodworking, a favorite hobby of Monk’s, symbolizes the straightforwardness and unambiguousness Monk aspires—and yet fails—to achieve in his everyday life, whether professionally or in personal or social settings.

Woodworking, unlike writing, requires no artful irony or subversion of form to make its intentions clear. If a person wants to build a chair, they build a chair—they don’t get there ironically or satirically by starting with an armoire and working their way backward, for instance. Wood, unlike language, is all surface. It has no hidden, implied alternate meanings: “the wood, the feel of it, the smell of it, the weight of it. It was so much more real than words.” Monk turns to woodworking because it gives him the clarity and validation that so often evades him in his regular life. Wood, unlike words or the people who use them, is not subject to interpretation or misinterpretation: “a table was a table was a table,” Monk proclaims, alluding to Gertrude Stein (“a rose is a rose is a rose”). In short, then, Monk’s reflections on woodworking express the frustration he feels at *My Pafology* being misinterpreted as genuine rather than satirical—and at himself for not being as decisively, morally opposed to

accepting payment for it as he wishes he were.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☛ The letter was unsigned. That was all that was in the box. I had read a voice of my father’s that I had not heard directly in life, a tender voice, an open voice. I couldn’t imagine the man who had run off to New York to have an affair. I knew my mother had read the letters, but I didn’t know when. I knew she wanted me to read the letters. Knowledge of the affair gave me, oddly, more compassion for my father, more interest in him. Even when I considered my mother and her feelings I did not find myself angry with him, though I worried about her pain.

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker), Mother, Bill, Father, Fiona

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 150

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Monk reflects on his late father’s affair, which he has just discovered after going through a box containing his father’s personal papers. In the box, Monk finds a series of letters from the woman his father was having an affair with, Fiona. Monk has always had a special relationship to his father, who wasn’t shy about his obvious favoritism toward Monk. Monk, in turn, did everything he could to earn his father’s approval. Notably, learning of this father’s affair doesn’t inspire feelings of hate or anger at the man. To the contrary, Monk describes feeling “more compassion” and “more interest in him,” even as he acknowledges the hurt the affair would cause Monk’s mother should she ever learn of it. This passage shows the depth of Monk’s idolatry toward his father, which has prevented him from looking at the man objectively as a child (when Monk tells his brother Bill about the affair later, Bill isn’t at all surprised to learn of their father’s infidelity) and from judging the man’s actions objectively now in his adulthood.

Notably, Monk recognizes that his lack of anger is “odd[.]”, though he doesn’t examine the oddity beyond simply acknowledging its existence. Nor does he consider how unfamiliar the “tender” and “open” tone his father conveys in his letters to Fiona is to him—growing up, Monk’s father was always stern, unyielding, and emotionally withholding. Monk’s altogether neutral response to his discovery of this secret points to just how much is at stake for Monk should he choose to rethink everything he once took as truth. Monk has effectively dedicated his entire life to becoming a person his father could be proud of. If his father’s ideals

crumple, so too does Monk's very sense of self.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☞ My mother's maiden name was Parker and they lived on the Chesapeake Bay, south of where we summered. A couple of Parkers were farmers, others worked in plants of one sort or another. Mother's brothers and sisters were considerably older and were all dead before I was an adult, leaving me with a herd of cousins that I never saw, never heard anything about, but kind of knew existed out there somewhere with names like Janelle and Tyrell. Mother had become an Ellison. As a child, I saw some Parkers only once, visiting a farm house near the bay. They frightened me. Big-seeming people with big smells and big laughs. Had I known more of life then, I would have liked them, found them thriving and interesting, but as it was, I found them only startlingly different.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Mother, Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 151

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Monk laments how "frightened" and dismissive he was toward his maternal relatives as a child. Unlike his father, who came from a long line of doctors, Mother's family "worked in plants of one sort or another" and didn't come from money. In this passage, Monk uses euphemistic language to portray the Parkers as uncultured and uneducated Black folks—they had "names like Janelle and Tyrell" and had "big smells and big laughs." Looking back, Monk suspects (perhaps wishfully) that he might "have liked them, found them thriving and interesting." But as a child, having only his father's impossibly high standards of excellence and specific aesthetic preferences to shape his sense of the world and his place in it, Monk could react to his mother's family only with fear. As a result, he found them "startling different"—and, he seems to imply, lesser.

Significantly, this passage comes directly after the chapter in which Monk discovers his father's affair. Although Monk claims that he feels no anger toward his father in light of the discovery, this passage indicates that he is at least starting to look critically at worldviews and personality traits of his father's that he accepted without question as a child. Here, he implicitly meditates on how his father's narrow view of what a successful, thriving Black family ought to look like caused him to be unfairly judgmental toward his mother's

side of the family—and perhaps still causes him to hold unfair prejudices toward people whose lives are different from his own.

☞ I hung up and stared at the phone on my desk. It was black and heavy and had been used by my father and sometimes I imagined I could still hear his deep voice humming through the wires. Bill sounded so remarkably sad, so lost. When we were kids I had often felt, however vaguely, his sadness, but this hopelessness, if it was in fact that, this lostness, misplacedness, was new and not easy to take.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Mother, Bill, Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 159

Explanation and Analysis

Monk hangs up the phone after speaking with Bill, whom he called to invite to the family beach house—Monk plans to take Mother there as a last trip before it's time to move her into a care facility due to her worsening Alzheimer's symptoms. Alone, Monk reflects on how "remarkably sad" Bill sounded on the phone—Bill is in the midst of a contentious divorce after his wife discovered his homosexuality, and it's put a great financial strain on him and cost him precious time with his young children. When Bill and Monk were children, Bill's homosexuality was obvious to people who knew him, but it wasn't something he publicly embraced for himself. As such, his sadness was something Monk could detect only "vaguely." Now, however, with Bill's complete and public embrace of his homosexuality, his sadness reaches a greater depth, conveying a "lostness, [a] misplacedness" that is impossible to miss.

Monk's reflection on the link between Bill's embrace of his homosexuality and his all-consuming sadness does not suggest that Bill's choice to embrace his sexuality is itself a selfish choice. Instead, it gestures toward the more general idea that honoring one's personal needs and desires is always a selfish choice in that it refocuses one's attention inward and thus stands the chance of alienating them from the outside world. The cost of authentic self-expression is an idea Monk contemplates himself as he contends with what his authoring *My Pafology* says about his moral and artistic integrity.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☞ I could never talk the talk, so I didn't try and being myself has served me well enough. But when I was a teenager, I wanted badly to fit in. I watched my friends, who didn't sound so different from me, step into scenes and change completely. [...]

I'd try, but it never sounded comfortable, never sounded real. In fact, to my ear, it never sounded real coming from anyone, but I could tell that other people talked the talk much better than I ever could. I never knew when to slap five or high five, which handshake to use. Of course, no one cared about my awkwardness but me, I came to learn later, but at the time I was convinced that it was the defining feature of my personality. "You know, Thelonious Ellison, he's the awkward one." *Talks like he's stuck up? Sounds white? Can't even play basketball.*

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 166-167

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Monk reflects on his struggles as a young child to fit in with the other Black teenagers. Those Monk's friends would normally not "sound so different from [him]," they were seemingly capable of switching from standard English to African American vernacular at the drop of a hat—something Monk himself couldn't do. When he tried, his words would come out sounding forced and unnatural. As a result, he felt alienated from his peers and painfully, irreparably uncool. Monk, as an adult, realizes that his "awkwardness," though perhaps noticeable, wasn't "the defining feature of his personality" he once thought it was. Nevertheless, his perceived sense of awkwardness and his fixation on how others perceived him clearly inform how he deals with many of the issues he grapples with in the novel's present, notably his struggle to create art that is authentic, honest, and intellectually rewarding for a publishing industry that fails to see beyond his race.

This passage thus sheds additional light on Monk's long, complex struggles with race and racial identity, and how his perceived failure to fit in with other Black youth as a child contributed to his rejection of the concept of race as an adult. Moreover, Monk's reflection on the disparity between the perceived awkwardness he felt as a child and the realization he comes to as an adult—that all this was likely only in his head—points to the competing forces that shape and skew a person's sense of self.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☞ Enemies always understand each other better than friends.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Lisa, Bill, Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 182

Explanation and Analysis

Monk thinks the above quotation during a phone call with Bill. Monk has just told Bill about his discovery of Father's affair, a revelation that doesn't shock Bill in the slightest. Bill's cynical reaction to Monk's news somewhat surprises Monk at first, but then he realizes that it makes sense that he is willing to give their father the benefit of the doubt, whereas Bill maintains no illusions about the man. Monk, it has always been clear to everyone, was their father's favorite. Bill and Lisa never managed to secure the praise and admiration that their father gave Monk in abundance (by comparison, at least). Bill's easy acceptance of the new knowledge of their father's affair shows Monk that his father's favoritism didn't bring Monk closer to his father—instead, it blinded Monk to his father's flaws. Monk, eager for praise and validation, had no incentive to question his father and examine him critically, and so he accepted his father without question. Bill, on the other hand, had to think critically and creatively to find ways to challenge and dismantle his father's lack of approval. As a result of that more critical, discerning perspective, Bill knows their father—his enemy—far better than Monk. Monk's reflection in this passage thus speaks to how Monk's idolatry of his father has skewed his perception of the man—and by extension, Monk's perception of the person he himself became in his quest to make his father proud.

☞ "Have you ever known anybody who talks like they do in that book?" I could hear the edge on my voice and though I didn't want it there, I knew that once detected, it could never be erased.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Stagg R. Leigh, Juanita Mae Jenkins, Marilyn Tilman

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 188

Explanation and Analysis

These are Monk's words to Marilyn during in an argument he initiates after finding a copy of Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* in Marilyn's house and angrily confronting her about it. When Marilyn, not understanding why Monk is so upset, responds that she liked the book, even if it wasn't the best thing she ever read, Monk challenges her on why she liked it. He criticizes the book for its offensive, inaccurate depiction of Black life ("Have you ever known anybody who talks like they do in that book?") and suggests that people who like it are unintelligent and unsophisticated. Marilyn, understandably, takes offense at this, and asks Monk to leave.

Monk, for his part, realizes that he is being unreasonable, even if he doesn't consciously realize it in the moment. In fact, Monk's anger at Marilyn is really misdirected anger at himself: by this point in the novel, *My Pafology*—the satire on books like *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* that Monk has penned under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh—has received high praise from publishers interested in securing the rights to the book. And Monk, in his precarious financial situation, hasn't been able to bring himself to turn down any of the advances he's been offered.

Thus, although Monk's anger at the publishing industry's troubling pattern of only publishing books like Jenkins's, which present a singular and oversimplified depiction of Black life in America, is justified, he's not really angry at Marilyn for supporting that culture. He's angry at his own complicity in it—and more importantly, at his failure to admit to this complicity, choosing instead to hide behind the persona of Stagg R. Leigh rather than own up to the subpar, problematic book he has written and from which he is benefitting financially.

Chapter 12 Quotes

☛☛ Somewhere in Hollywood, Wiley Morgenstein smoked a cigar and contemplated the commercial value of *My Pafology*. He sat poolside with a big man from New Jersey with whom he attended two years of school at Passaic Junior College thirty years earlier.

Wiley smiled and relit his cigar. "They go to the movies now, these people. There's an itch and I plan to scratch it."

Related Characters: Wiley Morgenstein (speaker), Thelonious "Monk" Ellison, Stagg R. Leigh

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 193

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Monk imagines what Hollywood producer Wiley Morgenstein might be doing and thinking as he considers whether to secure the film rights to *My Pafology*. In the hypothetical scenario Monk describes in his diary, Morgenstein sits "poolside," a setting that suggests his wealth and the remove it grants him from the average person. In Monk's cynical imagination, Morgenstein is a businessperson who is only interested in "the commercial value of *My Pafology*"—he, unlike figures in the publishing industry, has no pretense of trying to give voice to underrepresented voices. His interest in *My Pafology* and its elusive author, Stagg R. Leigh, is clear: he thinks they might be able to make him money.

Likewise, Wiley makes no effort to hide his casual racism with his observation that "They go to the movies now, these people," seemingly referring to Black people. "There's an itch and I plan to scratch it." In this hypothetical scene, Monk depicts Wiley's frank indifference to any of the social or political discussions tied to *My Pafology*. By portraying Wiley in this cynical way, Monk implicitly expresses his own feelings of shame and disappointment at creating *My Pafology* in the first place. Although he repeatedly struggles to admit it outright, Monk understands, at least on some level, that he too is complicit in (and benefits from) the system that Wiley and other people in positions of power cultivate and maintain.

Chapter 14 Quotes

☛☛ The fear of course is that in denying or refusing complicity in the marginalization of "black" writers, I ended up on the very distant and very "other" side of a line that is imaginary at best. [...] I never tried to set anybody free, never tried to paint the next real and true picture of the life of my people, never had any people whose picture I knew well enough to paint. [...] But the irony was beautiful. I was a victim of racism by virtue of my failing to acknowledge racial difference and by failing to have my art be defined as an exercise in racial self-expression. So, I would not be economically oppressed because of writing a book that fell in line with the very books I deemed racist. And I would have to wear the mask of the person I was expected to be.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Stagg R. Leigh, Mother

Related Themes:



Page Number: 212

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes Monk's thoughts in reaction to the commercial success of *My Pafology/Fuck*—most recently, a Hollywood producer expressed interest in securing the rights to a film adaption of the story. Monk struggles to know how to respond to the book's unexpected (and frankly disturbing) success in a way that allows him to maintain his artistic integrity (and his dignity) without refusing the life-changing benefits that financial stability could bring. On the one hand, he realizes it's foolish and impractical to turn down the hefty paychecks he's been offered in order to deny "complicity in the marginalization of 'black' writers." Monk isn't wealthy, and accepting the offers the publishing house (and later the production studio) have sent his way make a big difference in his ability to support himself and his ailing mother. Turning down those offers would not only be self-destructive, it would also be disingenuous: it's not as though Monk has otherwise sought to publish works of great social and political import and integrity. Refusing the financial stability that *My Pafology* has afforded him would be purely symbolic—a last-ditch effort to preserve his reputation as a serious artist.

Monk also addresses the convenient "irony" of his situation: for all the years he has refused to give in to the industry's expectation that Black writers publish books that explicitly speak to their personal relationship with racial identity and to the Black experience, he has experienced great financial hardship, struggling to find publishers willing to accept his novels. As a result, he has, ironically, become "a victim of the racism," taking a hard financial hit because of his refusal to write in a racially conscious style he deems offensive. In accepting the payments publishers have offered him for the rights to *My Pafology/Fuck*—a book Monk deems racist and oppressive—Monk grants himself the opportunity to overcome some of the disadvantage he has suffered due to his economic oppression.

Monk, in short, is confused. He wants to maintain his artistic integrity and his dignity, yet he also realizes how pointless it is to turn down life-changing amounts of money for the sake of something as petty and self-indulgent as artistic integrity.

☞ [...] There were books by John Grisham and Tom Clancy, a paperback of John MacDonald and things like that. Those books didn't bother me. Though I had never read one completely through, I had peeked at pages, and although I did not find any depth of artistic expression or any abundance of irony or play with language or ideas, I found them well enough written, the way a technical manual can be well enough written. Oh, so that's tab A. So, why did Juanita Mae Jenkins send me running for the toilet? I imagine it was because Tom Clancy was not trying to sell his book to me by suggesting that the crew of his high-tech submarine was a representation of his race (however fitting a metaphor). Nor was his publisher marketing it in that way. If you didn't like Clancy's white people, you could go out and read about some others.

Related Characters: Thelonious "Monk" Ellison (speaker), Mother, Juanita Mae Jenkins

Related Themes:



Page Number: 214

Explanation and Analysis

Monk describes his wait in the physician's office for details of Mother's first overnight stay at the care facility. As Monk waits for the doctor to arrive, he peers at the doctor's collection of books, spying some books by John Grisham, Tom Clancy, and other (white) writers of easily digestible but inoffensive fiction. Monk realizes that he's not terribly put off by the presence of these books, though none of them could be considered high art by a long shot. He wonders why this is so when Juanita Mae Jenkins's book inspires such anger—it's not as though her writing is markedly worse than these other authors. Ultimately, Monk concludes that what upsets him about Jenkins's book is that it purports to exist as a "representation of [her] race," a grossly inaccurate interpretation which, in Monk's mind, perpetuates negative stereotypes often tied to Black people. On the other hand, no one would ever assume that Clancy or Grisham writes as a representative of all white people. "If you didn't like Clancy's white people, you could go out and read about some others," reasons Monk. Ultimately, then, Monk concludes that his issue is not with Jenkins herself or even the mediocre book she has written—it's with the broader publishing industry that puts forth her novel as a representation of Black America.

Chapter 17 Quotes

☞ “God, I just love that,” Kenya says, shaking her head. “Now, I know some of you at home are thinking that some of the language is kinda rough, but let me tell you, it doesn’t get any more real than this. With this kinda talent, chile, don’t you think we ought to forgive our guest’s intense bashfulness?”

Audience applause, approval, endorsement, blessing.

Related Characters: Kenya Dunston (speaker), Thelonious “Monk” Ellison, Stagg R. Leigh, Van Go Jenkins, Cleona

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 251

Explanation and Analysis

The above quotation describes talk show host Kenya Dunston’s response to an excerpt from *Fuck* she just read aloud on her show. The excerpt in question depicted protagonist Van Go’s rape of Cleona. Kenya’s gushing praise for *Fuck*’s supposedly brilliant, raw language contrasts sharply with the actual event that language describes: a sexual assault. Her unabashed proclamation that she “just love[s]” this horrific scene reveals the superficiality and racism that underlies proponents of *Fuck* and the books Monk intended it to parody. In their eager willingness to dismiss—and indeed, perhaps even to embrace—the unforgivable, immoral behavior that Van Go commits in this scene and throughout *Fuck*, the novella’s readership implicitly reveals their belief that such behavior is normal and acceptable among Black people. In other words, they betray the lower standard of behavior to which they hold Black characters. Although the book’s supporters might claim that issues of systemic racism or personal struggle, if not justify, then at least explain why Go does the bad things he does, their willingness to accept Go’s reprehensible behavior as normal—and indeed, even their “approval, endorsement, blessing” of such behavior—implies that they hold Black people (suffering or otherwise) to a different standard of behavior than other races, which is itself fundamentally racist.

Chapter 18 Quotes

☞ I chose one of the TV cameras and stared into it. I said, “Egads, I’m on television.”

Related Characters: Thelonious “Monk” Ellison (speaker), Stagg R. Leigh, Van Go Jenkins, Clareece Jenkins (Go’s Mother / Mama), Tardreece/Baby Girl

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 266

Explanation and Analysis

Monk speaks this quote at the end of Chapter 18 when he reaches the stage to accept *The Book Award for Fuck* as Stagg R. Leigh. Notably, Monk’s direct address to the camera mirrors the lines the character Go speaks to the camera at the end of *My Pafology/Fuck*, when he is apprehended following a police chase. (“Hey, Mama.” I say, “Hey, Baby Girl. Look at me. I on TV.”) In referencing Go’s quote, Monk symbolically closes the distance he has thus far fought to maintain between himself and the Stagg R. Leigh persona, implicitly admitting to his authorship of *Fuck* and his consequential complicity in the publishing industry that creates and cultivates a market for such books. Monk, like the protagonist of *Fuck*, accepts the limiting and demeaning role society has carved out for him, taking what relative benefit such a role affords him. (Go gets to be on TV, if only because he has committed a crime; and Monk gets to support himself as an author, if only by writing books that comment reductively and offensively on the so-called authentic, Black experience.) *Erasure* thus ends on a cynical if ambiguous note, with Monk revealing his identity as Stagg R. Leigh and perhaps finally succeeding in his mission to make fools of the publishing industry figures who enthusiastically publish nonsense like *Fuck*—while simultaneously accepting his authorship of *Fuck* and thereby accepting his own complicity in that system.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Thelonious “Monk” Ellison, the diarist, is a writer of fiction. Monk has dark skin, curly hair, and “some of [his] ancestors were slaves.” He’s had unpleasant encounters with the police in several states. According to “society,” then, he’s Black. He also graduated *summa cum laude* from Harvard and comes from a family of doctors. Monk recalls a book agent at a party who once told him that he ought to stop “writing retellings of Euripides and parodies of French poststructuralists” and write novels about “the true, gritty real stories of black life.” Monk, for his part, hardly ever thinks about race. In fact, he doesn’t “believe in race.”

Now, Monk arrives in Washington to give a paper at a conference for the *Nouveau Roman* Society, not because he wants to but because it’s been a while since he visited home. Lisa, his older sister, didn’t offer to pick him up from the airport. Monk doesn’t think Lisa hates him, but she does seem to hold a grudge against him. She seems to think his life teaching college literature courses out in California is rather superficial compared to her work as a doctor, risking her life to deliver reproductive healthcare—including abortions—to low-income women. Monk’s older brother Bill is a plastic surgeon out in Scottsdale, Arizona. Monk hasn’t seen him in four years. Bill has a wife and two kids, though everyone knows he’s gay.

Monk checks into the Tabbard Inn, a B&B off Dupont Circle. After unpacking his things, he heads down to the lobby to call Lisa at her office. When she picks up, her voice is a mixture of disgruntled and bored. Lisa asks if Monk has visited their mother yet. When he says he hasn’t, she offers to pick him up and they can take Mother to dinner. Monk agrees.

Lisa arrives an hour later in her luxury coupe. She tells Monk he’d better be ready for Mother, who is “a little weird these days.” Monk, taken aback, says Mother has always seemed fine on the phone. Lisa replies that you can’t tell much from a five-minute phone conversation. She explains that Mother has been forgetting things lately. Several months ago, she paid all the bills twice. Now, Lisa is the one paying the bills and taking care of everything else. Lorraine is still around, of course, “stealing little things here and there.”

From the start, Erasure foregrounds Monk’s complicated relationship to race and racial identity. Although he claims not to “believe in race,” he does acknowledge (and resent) that society treats him differently due to his race. In this way, then, the novel gestures toward a distinction between race as an abstract construct and marker of difference (i.e., the sort of “race” that Monk doesn’t believe in) and race as a social construct (i.e., race not as a marker of difference, but as a justification for bigotry and inequality).



That Monk’s sister Lisa didn’t offer to pick him up from the airport, that Monk hasn’t been home in a while, and that he hasn’t seen his brother Bill in years all point to the strained nature of Monk’s family life. The reader doesn’t have many details about Monk’s family yet, but it seems clear that the family isn’t particularly close. What has caused this distance or whether things have always been this way remains yet unknown.



Notably, Monk chooses to stay at a hotel rather than with family, reinforcing his strained, impersonal relationship to at least his mother and sister.



Lisa’s euphemistic comment about Mother being “a little weird these days” seems to suggest that Mother is experiencing symptoms of cognitive decline or dementia. Her follow-up remark about how little one can discern from a five-minute phone call somewhat passively aggressively criticizes Monk for his lack of involvement in Mother’s care—with both of her brothers living on the opposite side of the country, it seems the majority of that care falls to Lisa.



Monk and Lisa ask each other about their respective work. Lisa grumbles about the “anti-abortionist creeps” who protest outside her clinic. They frighten her—recently, in Maryland, a sniper shot a nurse through a clinic window. After a pause, Lisa breaks the silence to praise Monk for his intelligence—he understands complex things and thinks about them even though he doesn’t have to. Bill, meanwhile, is a smart guy and good enough “butcher,” but that’s still all he is: a butcher.

Lisa’s complaints about the “anti-abortion creeps” who protest outside her clinic, and the news story about the sniper who shot a nurse in nearby Maryland underscores the importance—and danger—of Lisa’s work. Although Monk isn’t a medical doctor like she is, Lisa seems to maintain a deep respect for him, nevertheless, since his work comes from a place of sincerity, good intent, and reverence for humanity—unlike Bill, who Lisa insinuates is dispassionate about his work (he’s a “butcher”) and only cares about money, not his patients.



Monk and Lisa arrive at Mother’s house, where Mother greets Monk warmly. Then she turns to Lisa and asks whether she and Barry are pregnant yet. Lisa, for the umpteenth time, reminds Mother that she’s divorced. While Mother gets ready for dinner, Monk peers around the house. He comments on the ashes in the fireplace. Later, when Lisa confronts Mother about the ashes, Mother absently explains that she burned some documents that Father wanted burned after his death. Lisa reminds her that Father died seven years ago.

Although Mother’s confused question to Lisa is clearly a symptom of her cognitive decline, it also hints at her unconscious favoritism toward Monk, which perhaps helps to explain some of Lisa’s bitterness. The reference to Father’s death sheds more light on the seemingly tense, unhappy characteristic of the Ellison family. Meanwhile, Mother’s casual mention of some personal papers Father wanted her to burn after his death hints at possible secrets in the family’s history, building intrigue for Monk and readers alike.



After a mostly uneventful dinner, Lisa drops Monk off at the B&B. In his room, he finds a message from Linda Mallory, an author and fellow professor he has had sex with twice. Monk calls Linda back. She’s staying at the Mayflower and invites him over for a drink. Monk reluctantly agrees to meet her at the hotel bar. Linda is a woman who says she “like[s] to fuck,” but Monk thinks she might like saying it more than doing it. What Monk really dislikes about Linda, though, is her lack of literary talent. She’s among a group of writers who wrote experimental fiction in the 1960s, only surviving by publishing one another’s work. These people comprise most of the *Nouveau Roman* Society. They hate Monk because he’s had moderate success.

Monk’s frank, somewhat insulting characterization of Linda points to the performed, shifting nature of identity—he’s suggesting that Linda has cultivated an outer persona for herself (as someone who “like[s] to fuck”) that doesn’t necessarily align with her true character, even if she herself fails to recognize this discrepancy. The fluid, constructed nature of a person’s self-image and the self they project to the world will become important to Monk’s own character development, particularly when it comes to race and racial identity.



Monk meets Linda at the Mayflower. They talk shop, and Monk complains about the panel and the people on it. Linda unsubtly asks if Monk would like to go up to her room. Monk somewhat gracelessly shrugs off the question and returns to his own hotel after one drink.

Monk’s complaints about the publishing industry and the people in his field point to his dissatisfaction with his work. He doesn’t say so explicitly here, but frustration could stem from publishers’ criticism of Monk’s work as not “Black enough.” Monk’s rejection of Linda’s offer of sex hints at his more general sense of alienation.



CHAPTER 2

The next morning, Monk grabs breakfast at the B&B before heading over to the conference at the Mayflower. He feels totally indifferent about the whole thing and wonders why he even came. Still, he's a bit nervous: he knows the excerpt from his novel will upset some people. The first paper is fairly straightforward, if boring. When it's Monk's turn, the audience greets him with "a certain clearing of throats and not-quite-muttering." He takes the stage and proceeds to read:

F/V: Placing the Experimental Novel. F/V: a novel excerpt. The narration segues into the excerpt Monk reads aloud at the conference. *F/V* opens with the premise that the work's title "answers any question before it is raised," but then, in contradiction, suggests that perhaps the mere fact of its being a title is a "suggestion of negation." The narration continues on in this intentionally opaque and convoluted manner, focusing on Barthes's critical work *S/Z*, which it analyzes in the same, poststructuralist style in which Barthes analyzes Balzac's *Sarrasine* in that critical work. The excerpt focuses on narrative and representation, and how adequately (or inadequately) language is able to recreate the essence of what it purports to represent.

Monk finishes reading, and the audience responds with tepid applause. Davis Gimbel, the editor of the journal *Frigid Noir*, stands up and shouts obscenities at Monk. Monk senses that the man didn't understand a word of what Monk just read and calls out that he didn't mean to hurt Gimbel's feelings. Gimbel declares Monk a "mimetic hack."

Monk's nervousness shows that despite his obstinate, jaded attitude toward the publishing industry, he still cares a great deal about his work and wants to come off well. The audience's "clearing of throats and not-quite-muttering" hints at their general dislike of (or perhaps impatience toward) Monk and his work.



In both style and substance, Monk's novel is exaggeratedly, humorously opaque and confusing. While it's possible this is genuinely how he prefers to write, one can't help but note a forced, insincere quality in Monk's writing—there is nothing personal about it. Indeed, it resists the personal in favor of the detached, the technical. Perhaps, then, Monk's writing does reveal something true about Monk the writer, albeit indirectly: he is extremely guarded against the outside world and prefers not to let others get to know him. At the same time, the subject of his novel—on narrative and representation—outlines some of the themes Erasure will explore, such as the potential and limitations of narrative to represent and communicate truth fully and authentically.



Davis Gimbel's angry response to Monk's reading, regardless of whether Monk is correct (and Gimbel is only angry because he hasn't understood Monk's novel)—or whether Gimbel is justified in declaring Monk a "mimetic hack"—shows how Monk's style of writing (and by extension, the persona he presents to the outside world) alienates him from others, leaving him feeling isolated and misunderstood.



CHAPTER 3

Monk returns to his hotel to find a death threat written on a bookmark: "I'll kill you, you mimetic Philistine." The next day, he visits his sister's clinic in Southeast D.C. He introduces himself to the receptionist, Yvonne, as Lisa's brother. "The writer brother," exclaims Yvonne. Monk takes a seat next to a young woman with long blue fingernails. She holds a young boy in her lap. The woman asks what kind of books Monk writes. He says "novels," then amends this to "stories." The woman says her cousin gave her [Their Eyes Were Watching God](#) to read, and she liked it. She liked *Cane*, too. Monk asks the woman if she went to college, and she laughs as she tells him she didn't even finish high school. They stop talking then, and Monk feels like the stupid one for having assumed, wrongly, that the woman would be stupid.

While Monk waits for Lisa to be finished with her work, he recalls being 15 and attending his first real party. It was during the summer, in a part of Annapolis he'd never been to before. His friend Doug Glass took him. The other boys at the party have names like Clevon and Reggie, and they tease him mercilessly when they learn his name is Monk. Later, Monk tries to dance with a beautiful girl named Tina, but he becomes horribly self-conscious, especially after he gets an erection, and he runs from the house all the way to the city dock.

Monk spots Bill at the city dock, on the family boat with some of his friends, and he asks to hang out with them. Bill is annoyed but says yes. The other boys act awkward and eventually leave. Monk asks if he ruined Bill's party, but Bill says not to worry about it.

Back in the present, Lisa and Monk grab lunch. Monk mentions the woman with the blue fingernails from the waiting room. Lisa says the woman's name is Tamika Jones and that her kids are named Mystery and Fantasy.

Monk seems indifferent to (or perhaps even energized by) the death threat, presumably left by Gimbel. Whether by choice or as a coping mechanism, he has learned to let others' disapproval motivate rather than discourage him. Monk's interaction with the woman in the waiting room sheds light on his own racial bias: he unjustly (and incorrectly) assumed the woman was stupid and uneducated due to her race and class, when in fact she is quite well read and insightful. This complicates Monk's earlier, self-proclaimed disbelief in race—perhaps his rejection of race reflects his own confusion and conflicted feelings about his own racial identity, or even his internalized racism, than it does his ire at the stereotypes society (and the publishing industry in particular) attaches to him due to his Blackness.



This memory gives readers insight into how Monk's formative experiences have influenced his ideas about race and his racial identity as an adult. It seems that the embarrassment and social rejection he faced for not being "Black enough" as an adolescent has contributed toward the self-proclaimed disbelief in race he has assumed as an adult.



It's not clear when or why Monk lost touch with Bill, whom this scene presents as an empathetic and patient brother to Monk, offering Monk support and a sense of safety after Monk's embarrassing experience at the party.



The detail of Tamika's children being named Mystery and Fantasy—names that stereotypically suggest a lower-class, uneducated background—clashes with Monk's sense of Tamika as an intelligent, if downtrodden, woman, further complicating Monk's ideas about race, racial identity, and stereotypes.



After lunch, Monk and Lisa head to a bookstore to pick up a book for one of Lisa's coworkers who recently had a baby. Monk wanders into the Contemporary Fiction section in search of his own books but doesn't find them there. Instead, he finds them shelved in the African American Studies section—seemingly just because they were written by a Black author. Monk is about to say something to a staff member, but then he spots a poster for an upcoming reading of Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives In Da Ghetto*. He reads the opening paragraph, which is written in exaggerated Black vernacular. Lisa returns just then and asks Monk what's wrong, but Monk brushes off the question, and they leave. Lisa offers to loan Monk her car for the afternoon if he drops her off at work first, and he agrees.

The placement of Monk's books in the African American Studies section of the bookstore visually represents the pigeonholing he experiences from the publishing industry, which concludes that his works must be "Black" in subject matter simply because he is a Black author. He loathes authors like Jenkins who choose to capitalize on this pigeonholing, essentially writing stereotypical works about the so-called "Black" experience to satisfy the industry, sacrificing their artistic integrity in the process.



CHAPTER 4

Monk drives around for a while before heading to his mother's house. As she makes them some tea, he reminds his mother to be careful about burning things in the house. When he asks her what she was burning, she vaguely explains that it was just "some papers" Monk's father wanted her to burn after his death. He also asked her not to read them, so she didn't. Later, Monk recalls how his father had only acted overtly proud of Monk when Monk had given him a story he'd written that was "purposely confusing and obfuscating."

The detail of Monk's father simply telling his wife to burn the papers, rather than burning them himself, points to the asymmetrical power dynamics that govern Monk's parents' relationship (and perhaps Ellison family life in a broader sense). He manage to exert emotional influence over his wife, even from beyond the grave. The detail of Monk's father only acting proud of young Monk after he produced a story that was "purposely confusing and obfuscating" sheds light on why Monk writes in the style he does—it seems tied to his desire to please his father.



Monk and Lisa drop by Mother's house later that evening. Monk greets their servant Lorraine, who has worked for the Ellisons since before he was born. Over dinner, Lisa broaches the subject of needing to sell Father's office, which costs too much to maintain. Mother protests, wanting to hold on to it for sentimental value. Monk interjects that Mother never visits the office anyway, and Mother immediately changes her mind and agrees to sell it. After dinner, sitting in Lisa's car outside his hotel, Monk apologizes for the comment about the office. Lisa says it's okay. Both their parents—and Lisa herself—always thought Monk was special. Monk says he thinks the same thing about Lisa.

Mother displays favoritism toward Monk when she automatically changes her mind about keeping Father's office after Monk offers his input. Monk's apology to Lisa afterward confirms this favoritism—he's aware that his parents have treated him differently and how this has affected his siblings. Lisa's graceful response shows her empathy and emotional intelligence—she can see Monk for the person he is beyond their parents' perception of him. She knows that he is special in his own regard. Although Lisa and Monk aren't particularly close, it's clear that they love and respect each other.



Monk encounters Linda Mallory in the hotel lobby. She asks if he'd like to go upstairs and have sex. Monk declines her offer, and she angrily storms out of the building. Monk steps outside as well and runs straight into Davis Gimbel, who angrily accuses Monk and "[his] kind" for interrupting what Gimbel's literary movement was trying to accomplish. Monk shrugs Gimbel off and heads back inside. Later, on the plane back to California, Monk reads a review in a literary magazine for Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives In Da Ghetto*. The review praises the novel as a raw, authentic depiction of the Black experience in America.

This comically dramatic encounter with Davis Gimbel and his cronies places Monk as an outsider up against an in crowd, a dynamic that reappears in other situations in Monk's life, as in the early flashback scene to the party he attended as a teenager. Repeatedly, Monk feels alienated from the masses and confused about who he is or ought to be. This will remain one of his central conflicts as the story unfolds.



CHAPTER 5

Monk returns to California feeling restless. The next morning, he receives a letter from his agent, Yul, informing him that his latest novel has been rejected. In a brief interlude, Monk describes some techniques he uses in his hobby of fly **fishing**. Monk's semester wraps up fine, and he learns that he has been promoted to professor. Still, he feels depressed over the rejection of his latest novel. On the phone later, Yul informs him that it's because he's "not black enough." Monk gripes about the stereotypical garbage that people like Juanita Mae Jenkins write. Yul agrees, but he reminds Monk that "it sells." Monk hangs up the phone, only for it to ring almost immediately after. It's Lorraine, telling him that Lisa is dead. Monk calls Bill, and they both make plans to travel home. Inwardly, Monk struggles to make sense of the words Lorraine spoke to him.

Yul's explanation for why Monk's latest novel was rejected is one Monk has heard time and again: it's "not black enough," meaning the book's plot and themes don't adhere to the limited boundaries the publishing industry (and perhaps, too, society as a whole) has carved out for Black writers. The mass culture, it seems, isn't interested in consuming Black art unless it explicitly focuses on a narrowly defined vision of Black life. This is something white authors don't have to deal with—they are not defined by their race. But the shocking news of Lisa's death pulls Monk away from his professional woes, forcing him to confront the familial and interpersonal conflicts of his life.



Monk arrives in Washington and heads to Mother's house. Bill greets him at the door and tells him that Mother is sleeping. Then he explains what happened to Lisa: an anti-abortion picketer shot her at the clinic. Later, Monk goes to Lisa's apartment, noting how "full of life" it appears, with art hanging on the walls, and the bed neatly made. He sees the **wooden** ring box he made for her some years ago. He remembers hoping she'd like it as much as he liked making it.

In retrospect, the detail of Lisa's apprehension over the nurse who was recently shot in Maryland was foreshadowing for Lisa's own tragic murder. Throughout Erasure, Monk's hobby of woodworking symbolizes his desire for certainty and clarity in his artistic pursuits, values, and relationships—woodworking is all about surfaces, after all. Thus, his focus on the wooden ring box in this scene perhaps reflects his regret at not having more moments of genuine, mutual understanding with Lisa—at all the times he put up walls that shut her (and others) out.



Later, after Lisa's funeral, Bill asks Monk if he's still doing **woodwork**. Monk asks about Bill's wife Sandy and the kids, and Bill says that Sandy divorced him and took everything after finding out that he was gay. His practice is also failing as a result. But Bill maintains that he deserves all the grief that Sandy is giving him—he lied to her for years. Monk feels bad about Bill's situation, but he's also disappointed to hear that Bill isn't in a financial condition to help out with Mother's care. Not long after Lisa's funeral, Monk moves in with Mother and Lorraine.

Bill feels his "punishment" from Sandy is worth it because he feels that being insincere with others is one of the most indefensible, inhumane things a person can do, representing a betrayal of others and of one's authentic self. Bill's mention of woodworking before shifting to the subject of his divorce further underscores woodworking as representing the connection (or lack thereof) between one's outer persona and one's inner sense of self.



CHAPTER 6

Monk decides to take a leave of absence after the extent of Mother's mental deterioration becomes clear. He wants her to stay in her home and with Lorraine. He reasons that he'll only have to stay for a year because by then, Mother will likely be dead. Later, he watches Juanita Mae Jenkins's appearance on a talk show hosted by Kenya Dunston, who put *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* on her Book Club reading list. Kenya gushes about the book. Ms. Jenkins explains that she is from Ohio originally and attended Oberlin for college. She spent a few days with relatives in Harlem, and that's what inspired the book. She wanted to publish a real, raw book about "our people." Miss Jenkins confirms that she's sold the film rights to the book but coyly refuses to say for how much.

Monk, meanwhile, worried about financing Mother's care, applies for a job in the English Department at American University. Despite Monk's lengthy CV, the best the chair of the department can offer him is a temporary job lecturing an American Literature survey course in the fall.

Later, Monk encounters Lorraine in the kitchen. She praises him for moving home to help Mother. After a pause, Monk asks her if she has family in the area and she says no—Monk's family is the only one she's known. Monk asks her where she'd go if Mother died, and Lorraine replies that she'd stick around and take care of Monk. Later, Monk and Mother talk about how much they miss Lisa. But moments later, Mother asks if she said something to offend Lisa—she can't think of another reason why Lisa hasn't visited her lately.

Monk calls Yul sometime later to ask how his latest novel is doing. Yul tells him that three more editors have declined to take it on. "The market simply won't support this kind of thing," one of them said. Yul suggests that Monk write another book like *Second Failure*, an earlier novel of Monk's about a young Black boy who struggles to understand why the community ostracizes his white mother. Monk hated writing it, but it sold well.

Monk's choice to take a leave of absence represents a shift in his priorities. He has long put his career and his art over family and personal obligations, but now he sets his career aside to care for his declining mother. Perhaps this shift in priorities will help Monk to undertake some of the self-reflect he so desperately needs. The interview with Jenkins points to how inaccuracy of reviewers who have deemed her novel "real" and "raw." In fact, her background (she attended an elite, private college and didn't grow up in the impoverished, urban atmosphere about which she writes) suggests great economic privilege.



The juxtaposition of the previous scene (which describes Jenkins's immense financial success) with this scene, which emphasizes Monk's mounting financial woes, lays the foundation for Monk's bitterness toward the publishing industry and authors like Jenkins who have no qualms about selling out.



Monk has returned home to help Mother as her health declines. Notably, Lisa's recent, unexpected death is what triggers Monk's choice to move home. Although there's a practical reason for this (Lisa was Mother's primary helper, and now she's no longer around to fill that role), it also seems that Lisa's death has shown Monk that the time he has left with his loved ones can be cut short. Thus, his relocation to D.C. seems motivated, in part, by his desire to reconnect with his mother while he still can. Of course, as this scene shows, Monk may be too late, with Mother's cognitive function worsening by the day.



On the one hand, Monk's refusal to write books that appeal to mass audiences signals his commitment to upholding his artistic integrity. On the other, it perhaps reveals his inability or unwillingness to confront his own complicated feelings toward race and racial identity—and in a broader sense, to lay bare his inner self.



Later that night, Monk goes to his father's old study. He stares at an image of Juanita Mae Jenkins on the cover of *Time* magazine and thinks about some passages from [Native Son](#) and [The Color Purple](#). Then his hands begin to shake, and before he can understand what he's doing, the words, "Why fo you be axin?" come out of his mouth. Then Monk sits down before his father's old typewriter and begins to write. He knows he can never put his name on this book. Instead, he writes *My Pafology* by Stagg R. Leigh.

Monk pens My Pafology, a satire on the so-called "ghetto" literature he so loathes, to work through his frustration over his ongoing financial woes and the repeat rejections he receives from publishing houses. But as the saying goes, all jokes contain at least a kernel of truth. Along these lines, the reader shouldn't interpret My Pafology as merely a cynical, satirical expression of Monk's ire at the publishing industry—it must also be considered as a reflection of Monk's real thoughts and feelings about race, racial identity in America, and his various other interpersonal conflicts.



MY PAFOLGY: WON

Mama looks at the narrator—Van Go Jenkins—and his sister Tardreece (Baby Girl) and calls them "human slough." Van Go—or "Go" for short—doesn't know what "slough" means, but he's angry. So he picks up a big knife and starts stabbing Mama. "I stab Mama cause I love her. I stab Mama cause I hate her. [...] Cause I ain't got no daddy," Go thinks as he stabs. Then he wakes up, covered in sweat. He puts on some dirty clothes and steps outside, wondering which of his four babies he'll see today. Go decides to visit Rexall's mom, Cleona. Rexall "got Down Sinder," but that's fine.

*The story of Van Go Jenkins relies on exaggerated stereotypes of Black struggle—Van Go's name (a phonetic misspelling of Van Gogh) suggests his (high-brow) cultural illiteracy and his lacking formal education, for instance. Also notable is the foregrounding of gratuitous violence. Stereotypes like these are common fixtures in the "ghetto" literature Monk hates. Notably, Van Go's story closely resembles the plot of Richard Wright's [Native Son](#). At the same time, the reader can't help but see Monk's ongoing troubles with Mother in Go's simultaneous "love" and "hate" for Mama. It's clear, then, that Monk is using *My Pafology* to work through some of his real ongoing issues, however feigned or satirical the plot of the story may be.*



Go is 19 and doesn't care about anything or anyone because the world doesn't care about him. Cleona always talks about graduating and becoming a nurse. Lately, though, she's been acting like she's too good for Go. He resolves to go over to her place and put her in her place. As Go waits for Cleona outside the high school, he spots Willy the Wonker walking down the street toward him. He's always singing and swaying, visibly on drugs. When Van Go rudely tells him to back off, Willy the Wonker laughs and insinuates he had sex with Van Go's mom and might be Van Go's father.

*Go's anger at the world is extreme to an exaggerated degree, for satirical effect. In Monk's satire on urban literature, he represents the angry, disillusioned young Black man who lives at the margins and shirks the laws of civilized society. At the same time, Go's sense of alienation reflects Monk's own struggle to connect with and feel accepted by mainstream culture, even if this isn't Monk the writer's intention in writing *My Pafology*.*



Finally, school lets out, and Cleona walks out the door. She's talking to a rich guy named Tyrell, which upsets Go. Go suggests he and Cleona go over to her house so he can see Rexall. She agrees to let Go come over but says she has to be back at school in an hour. Inwardly, Van Go reflects on his two selves, "Nigger A and Nigger B." A loves Cleona and wants what's best for her. But B wants to hurt her and have sex with her.

Go continues to exhibit stereotypical traits typically found in characters of urban literature: namely, he is torn between two selves, a genuine self that wants to do good ("Nigger A") and an angry, destructive self ("Nigger B")—the result of systemic racism and discrimination—whose anger prevents that true, good self from shining through.



At Cleona's house, Go notices a new couch, which upsets him. He insinuates that Cleona engaged in sex work to pay for it, and Cleona retorts that he's supposed to pay her child support for Rexall but never does. Go apologizes to Cleona and starts touching her. Cleona is receptive at first but then tells him to stop. But Go doesn't stop and proceeds to rape her, ejaculating onto the couch. Cleona screams that she hates him and demands that he leave, screaming that he raped her. Go just laughs and walks out.

Go's rape of Cleona is calculated and morally indefensible. Monk includes the scene to point out the hypocrisy and self-delusion of readers who empathize with so-called "morally ambiguous" protagonists such as Go, suggesting that this empathy actually betrays readers' racism rather than anti-racism: it's as though they hold Black, marginalized characters to a lower standard of conduct.



MY PAFOLGY: TOO

Go heads to the pool hall to meet up with his friends Yellow and Tito. They get into a fight with some other guys, and one pulls a gun on Go. After the men leave, Go remarks that he has to get a gun. The first thing he'll do with it is rob the Korean man at the plaza who always looks at Go like he's going to rob him. Yellow calls Van Go "crazy." To this, Van Go simply explains, "Gots to be crazy to survive." They start insulting one another's mamas.

*Adding yet another negative stereotype to the mix, this scene shows Go's lack of ambition, his vengefulness, and his propensity toward violence. Go's line, "Gots to be crazy to survive," is melodramatic and "deep" to an exaggerated, comic degree, poking fun at the sort of "raw," "real" writing for which Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives in Da Ghetto* has been praised.*



On his walk home later, Go approaches an attractive Black woman stepping out of a red Mustang. When she sees him, she jolts up and points a can of pepper spray at him. He calls her "baby doll," and she tells him to buzz off. "Kindly move along," says the woman. Go mocks her for the stuffy language and accuses her of being "uppity." He watches her drive off and wants to scream.

Go's misogyny and disdain for the woman's "uppity" way of speaking and apparent wealth further establishes him as a bitter, unlikeable character. Again, Monk is playing up traits typically seen in characters of urban fiction to satirize the genre, showing how it is (in Monk's eye) insulting and derogatory to Black people, as are people who consume and praise such literature.



MY PAFOLGY: FREE

Mama and Baby Girl are just getting back from grocery shopping when Go arrives home. Go bickers with Baby Girl. Mama scolds him for swearing, so he swears at her, too. Then he angrily storms off to the other room to watch TV. He tells Mama to call him when it's time to eat. When dinner is ready, Mama calls Go into the kitchen. He sits down at the table and complains about the Hamburger Helper Mama and Baby Girl made, then calls Mama fat. Mama loses it, picking up a knife and pointing it at Go. Baby Girl screams at Mama not to hurt Go. Go gets up, knocking a chair over, and heads out. He wanders the streets and encounters the rich guy with the Jeep whom Cleona was talking to earlier. They get into a fight, and Go punches the Jeep guy's face into a bloody mess.

Not only does Go disrespect women he encounters on the street, but he also has no respect for his mother or sister, who provide him with shelter, food, and emotional support—to a point. When Mama pulls a knife on Go, it shows how Go's bitterness and anger worsens the misfortune and strife he's been unjustly dealt in life. In his confused anger and bitterness, he pushes away those who try to help him. Scenes like this, though they don't necessarily show Go in a positive light, at least portray him as tragic. Try as Monk may to craft a one-dimensional, exaggerated caricature of the angry Black youth, some humanity and honesty slips through.



Eventually Go heads home. That night, he dreams he's on an island full of beautiful, skimpily dressed women. He dreams of all the babies he'll have with them and the names he'll give them, going through the ABCs: "Avaricia, Baniqua, Clitoria, [...] Fantasy, [...] Mystery [...]." But then he looks down at his penis and sees it's just a bump. All the women laugh at him as he tries to cover himself. Then he wakes up, covered in sweat.

This scene reverts to pure, mocking satire, with Go's irresponsibility, toxic masculinity, and (for lack of a better word) stupidity on full display with his dream of fathering a whole alphabet of babies he can't afford to pay for. Note the names Fantasy and Mystery, which Monk took from Tamika Jones, the woman he spoke with in the waiting room of Lisa's clinic. This detail reinforces the degree to which My Pafology draws from Monk's own life and experiences.



At breakfast the next morning, Mama tells Go about a job she's heard about in West Hollywood that involves driving a car around for a rich man. Go doesn't want to be some white man's chauffeur, but Mama gives him a piece of paper with the man's address written on it anyway. Go pockets the paper. Later, as Mama is washing the dishes, Go confronts her about his father. What's his name? Mama tells him to shut up. Go storms out.

Once more, My Pafology—despite being a work of obstinate, angry satire—points to some of the conflicts Monk is working through in his real life. In this scene, Go's anger at Mama for not being forthcoming—with Go or with herself—about Go's father mirrors Monk's frustration with his own mother for her refusal to talk about his father's personal papers.



MY PAFOLGY: FO

Go heads to the warehouse where he works. When the manager tells him that he no longer has a job since he missed three shifts in a row, Go decides to check out the job Mama told him about. He takes a bus and arrives at a big house on a hill. There's a red BMW convertible parked out front. He rings the doorbell, and a Black man wearing a pink shirt and khakis answers. When the man introduces himself as Mr. Dalton, Go is shocked—he assumed the man would be white. Go pulls himself together and says he's here about a job. A large Black woman—Lois—appears behind the man and explains that Go is the son of her good friend. Mr. Dalton agrees to hire Go and that Lois will get him settled.

*Mr. Dalton is the name of a character in Richard Wright's [Native Son](#), which My Pafology blatantly parodies. Monk's Mr. Dalton plays a similar role to Wright's, though Wright's Dalton is white, not Black. Go's decision to pursue the job opportunity his mother arranged for him adheres to another convention of the stereotypical urban-fiction narrative arc, in which the angry, underachieving, oppressed protagonist is given a chance to rise up. In Erasure, Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives in Da Ghetto* follows a similar arc.*



Once they're alone, Lois sternly tells Go that she's giving him this chance as a favor to his mama. If he makes one mistake, he's gone. Go agrees, albeit grudgingly. Lois shows him around the massive, opulent property. Then she hands him a broom and tells him to sweep everything. Go does as he's told. When he's done, Lois says she'll see him tomorrow. Before heading home, Go decides to stop by the pool hall, where he meets up with Tito and Yellow. He tells them about his new job. Tito instructs Van Go to make a list of all the valuables in the house so they can rob Mr. Dalton.

Lois's harsh advice to Go and Tito's subsequent scheme to rob Mr. Dalton seems to foreshadow Go's eventual failure. Given what readers know about his aimlessness and self-destructive tendencies, it's more likely that he'll blow this opportunity, not rise above adversity to improve his quality of life. In My Pafology, Monk exaggerates the degree to which Go willingly acts against his self-interest in order to critique the stereotype of the disadvantaged Black protagonist whom society and institutional racism dooms to failure.



Later, Go, Yellow, and Tito spot a girl with a large behind. Go approaches her and says, “Hey baby.” She introduces herself as Kesrah and says she’s headed home and that her mama won’t be there. Tito tells Van Go to be careful—the girl looks about 14. Van Go shrugs this off and fantasizes about having sex with her. He tells her he’s going to give her a baby.

Monk continues to write a character so inarguably horrible and immoral—this chapter ends with him apparently heading off to commit statutory rape—testing the limits of his envisioned audience’s limits to empathize with the urban (Black) downtrodden.



MY PAFOLGY: FIBE

Van Go follows Kesrah to her house, where Kesrah’s uncle is drunk and passed out on the couch. In her room, Kesrah removes her clothing, and Go insults her for being flat chested. Then Go “get[s] on top her.” She cries and says it hurts, but Go knows “she like it.” After, she asks Go if he’ll be back. Go says no—she’s too young for him. Go berates her some more and she starts to cry. Kesrah’s uncle comes into the room. Kesrah tells her uncle that Go raped her, and the man lunges at Go. Go runs from the house.

This is the second time Go has committed sexual assault, and My Pafology isn’t even halfway through. Monk continues to write horrible scenes like this to make fools of readers who empathize with the morally bankrupt protagonists of conventional works of urban fiction.



Go is heading to the pool hall to tell Yellow and Tito about his encounter when the Jeep guy and his crew pull up alongside him. Go makes a run for it, seeking shelter in an abandoned building. There, he encounters Willy the Wonker. Willy brings up Mama again and makes a crude remark about her body. Go is about to beat him up, but Willy tells him to stop and listen. Willy messed up in life, and he doesn’t want Go to do the same.

Willy the Wonker continues to reenter Go’s story, haunting and antagonizing Go as he simultaneously cautions Go to learn from his (Willy’s) errors and be better. This somewhat reflects Monk’s own conflicted relationship with his late father, who shaped Monk’s identity in profound but not necessarily positive ways. Once more, although Monk writes My Pafology as an over-the-top parody of so-called “ghetto fiction,” his genuinely felt inner conflicts infiltrate the narrative.



At the pool hall later, when Go starts to brag about having sex with Kesrah, Tito admonishes him. “Fuckin children and havin babies don’t make you no man,” he tells Go. They bicker some more, and Go eventually storms off.

If even Go’s delinquent friends call him out on his immoral behavior, Go must really be a horrible person. Monk closes the chapter on this note to call out publishers and readers who extend empathy to such characters, a move Monk sees as ultimately racist, as it reveals the low standards they have for Black people.



MY PAFOLGY: SEX

After having breakfast with Mama and Baby Girl the next morning, Go take a bus to Mr. Dalton’s. When he get there, Lois commends him for only being a little late. Today, his job is to wash Mr. Dalton’s cars. While he’s working on one of the cars, someone calls out to him. He turns and sees a young woman in a bikini. She introduces herself as Penelope and explains that she’s Mr. Dalton’s daughter. She goes to Stanford. Penelope asks Go if her dad pays him well, and Go says the pay is fine. Then Penelope asks if Go can drive. Go says yes, and Penelope runs inside to change. She emerges wearing a short, tight dress.

In Monk’s parody on [Native Son](#), Penelope functions as a stand-in for the character Mrs. Dalton. In Wright’s novel, the protagonist Bigger Thomas murders Dalton’s daughter, so things don’t look great for Penelope.



Penelope orders Go to drive her to a fancy restaurant in Santa Monica. There, they pick up a well-dressed Black man, who introduces himself as Roger. Roger tells Go to drive them to the “hood” so they can eat some chicken and buy some weed. Penelope, laughing with Roger, tells Go to drive to “someplace colorful to eat.” Penelope and Roger’s laughter irritates Go, but he tries to hide it and drives them to a rib place. Roger and Penelope eat their ribs and bemusedly ask Go questions about his life. They crack up when Go says he has four babies with four different women.

After, Go drives Penelope and Roger, who have started drinking out of a flask in the backseat, to pick up weed. On the drive back to Penelope’s, Roger fondles Penelope, who is nearly passed out. Go asks Roger if they get intoxicated like this every day, but Roger doesn’t answer.

It’s nearly dark when Go and Penelope arrive back at Mr. Dalton’s. Penelope is still out of it and starts to sing. She tells Go to take her to the pool house. Penelope collapses into a lounge chair, and Go starts to fondle her. A woman calls out for Penelope, and Go freezes, placing a hand over Penelope’s mouth to keep her quiet. But then Go sees the woman’s cane and realizes, relieved, that she’s blind. After the woman leaves, Go spreads Penelope’s legs apart and “stabs her.” She doesn’t wake up.

MY PAFOLGY: SEBEN

Baby Girl wakes Go up the next morning and excitedly tells him that Snookie Cane is on the phone and wants him to appear on the Snookie Cane Show. Go thinks it’s a joke at first, but then he picks up the phone and finds that it’s actually Snookie Cane. She says that a guest on the show has a crush on him and wants to surprise him. They’re taping a show today at 1:00 p.m.—can Go make it? Go says yes. Baby Girl catches Mama up to speed, and then the three of them catch a ride to the studio with their neighbor Quanita-Mack.

Go, Mama, Baby Girl, and Quanita-Mack arrive at the studio. A producer named Gloria leads him backstage to a gay Black man (Go uses two slurs to describe him) to get him touched up for the camera. When Go is ready, Gloria instructs him to wait for a red light for his cue to walk on stage. When the light flashes, Go walks onstage—and comes face to face with his “fo’ babies sittin on they fo’ mamas’ laps”—Aspireene on Sharinda’s; Tylenola on Reynisha’s; Dexatrina on Robertarina’s; and Rexall on Cleona’s. The audience boos Go as he walks across the stage.

Penelope and Roger fill a similar role to the publishers whom Monk hates: they (or at least Penelope) pretend to empathize with the plight of marginalized people of color like Go while simultaneously belittling them, as when Penelope and Roger laugh at Monk’s adhering to the stereotype of the Black man who carelessly fathers children he cannot afford to support.



Here, the narrative makes an obvious, sweeping point about the double standards applied to marginalized Black people and people of privilege: Roger and Penelope behave as recklessly as Go, yet it affords them lenience it does not extend to Go.



It’s unclear whether Go actually stabs Penelope or whether the narration is using a crude euphemism to describe Go’s act of raping her. Notably, the stabbing imagery in this scene parallels Go’s dream of stabbing Mama in My Pafology’s opening chapter, suggesting that Go has fulfilled a destiny of sorts, becoming the criminal that society has predetermined him to be.



The phone call from Snookie Cane seems out of the blue and rather odd. But Go, who repeatedly acts selfishly in pursuit of his own self-interest, doesn’t seem to find anything suspicious about it. Go’s seeming naivety about the ordeal adds to Monk’s satirical criticism of the two-dimensional characters featured in works of urban fiction.



The homophobic language Go uses to describe the gay makeup artist mirrors Monk’s judgmental attitude toward Bill’s new openness about his homosexuality. Once more, the inner conflicts Monk can’t bring himself to reflect on directly seep into the narration of My Pafology, suggesting the bitterness or perhaps jealousy he feels toward Bill’s courage to be his authentic self.



Snookie Cane stands in the middle of the audience and smugly welcomes Go. She tells him the name of today's show: "You gave me the baby, Now where's the money." Go claims to have paid the women child support, but they all call him a liar. He swears at them, using derogatory language. The audience boos at his belligerent attempts to justify his actions. One man in the audience suggests that Go has low self-esteem about his manhood.

Go looks into the audience and sees Mama sitting in the front row. She starts to cry. Snookie Cane notices and asks Mama who she is. Between sniffles, Mama tells the audience that she's Go's mom and that she didn't raise him to act this way. A white man in the audience interjects to say that Go can't treat the women on stage with respect because he doesn't even respect his own mother.

Just then, Snookie Cane turns to Go and tells him they have another surprise for him. She asks if he knows who Penelope Dalton is—and then two police officers come through the door and make their way toward Go. Snookie informs the audience that Go raped Penelope last night. Go springs out of his chair and runs through the audience. A gay man in the audience who's been heckling Go tries to stop Go, but Go knees him, and the man collapses. Go runs out of the building.

MY PAFOLGY: ATE

Go wanders around some alleys for a while—it doesn't seem wise to return to his hood yet. He runs into Reynisha, who points a gun at him and threatens to shoot. Go distracts her and steals the gun. Reynisha threatens to tell the police Go has a gun. She hopes they kill him.

Go takes the gun and walks downtown. He ducks into a store when he sees a police car headed his way down the street. The store is lined with TVs. Images of his appearance on the *Snookie Cane Show* flash across all the screens. Go leaves the store and wanders the streets until he ends up back at the hood. He heads to the Korean man's store to get revenge. The man recognizes Go immediately. He reaches down under the front counter to grab something. When the man tries to reach for his shotgun, Go shoots him in the head. Go grabs the money from the register and runs.

As the reader may have anticipated, the story about a secret admirer was merely a setup to orchestrate Go's ambush by the four women with whom he has fathered children. Go's unapologetic lies about making child support payments draw from negative stereotypes about Black men who father children they can't afford to support.



This scene adds to the melodrama of My Pafology, with Go continuing to disregard the emotions and general wellbeing of the people who care for him most. Go's shameful indifference to Mama's tears reinforces his poor character. This adds to Monk's satirical criticism of the low bar to which audiences hold the two-dimensional characters in novels like what My Pafology satirizes.



This scene confirms that Go raped but did not kill Penelope, a key difference between My Pafology and Richard Wright's [Native Son](#), the novel whose plot My Pafology most closely parodies. In that novel, the protagonist (Bigger Thompson) kills Mr. Dalton's daughter, Mary Dalton.



Go continues to act recklessly and against his self-interest, stealing a gun from Reynisha. His exaggeratedly poor decision-making capabilities add to the two-dimensionality of his character and reinforces My Pafology's satirical tone.



Go's troubles mount as he adds murder and robbery to the list of crimes he has accumulated over the course of My Pafology, adding to the novella's satirical tone. In the type of novel My Pafology parodies, Go's reckless behavior would point to how society, in looking down on Go and depriving him of opportunity, has doomed him to this unfortunate fate. But in My Pafology, Monk intends for the melodrama and unbelievability of Go's actions to strike a dark, satirically humorous tone.



Go takes shelter in an abandoned building. He falls asleep and dreams that a big white man is making him run laps around the court to try out for the basketball team. He laughs and laughs and tells Go he's running wrong. Then he makes Go run backward. After a while, Go realizes he has no shoes on and that his feet are bleeding. Willy appears in the dream then. He tells Go he was wrong to say that he and Go "ain't shit"—"I is shit and so is you," Willy announces, laughing.

The white man who makes Go run laps and laughs as he struggles is meant to emphasize how the systemic racism of Go's society sets him up for failure, but the obviousness of the metaphor contributes to My Pafology's satirical tone, as does Go's melodramatic final confrontation with Willy the Wonker, his maybe-father. At the same time, Go's murder of Willy reflects Monk's genuinely conflicted, confused relationship with his own late father.



MY PAFOLGY: NINE

Go walks up the next morning and heads over to the pool hall. He climbs in through the back window and falls asleep in one of the stalls. He wakes up later and finds Tito and Yellow there. They've seen Go's TV appearance and tell him the police are looking for him—the Korean man's murder was caught on the security camera. Go threatens Fat Man, who runs the pool hall, with his pistol and orders him to give him his car. Fat Man yields, and Go runs off with the keys.

The pool hall setting is another reference to Richard Wright's [Native Son](#), the novel whose plot My Pafology most closely parodies—in that novel, the protagonist (Bigger Thomas) convenes with his friends at the pool hall. Tension builds as Go continues to evade the police—it seems unlikely at this point (and perhaps has seemed unlikely from the start) that things will end well for Van Go Jenkins.



MY PAFOLGY: TIN

Go is driving Fat Man's Ford Torino when he hears helicopters above him. In his panic, he misses the exit to head south to Mexico. He's nearly out of gas now, so he pulls off the freeway and walks into a post office yielding his gun. The people inside start to panic. An old woman asks him why he's doing this, and he says, "I ain't had no life," in response. Meanwhile, the police assemble outside. Go grabs a teenage girl and walks outside with her. He threatens to shoot her if the police try anything. Then he demands a car. The police tell him they have one on the way.

Go's ineptitude emphasizes the two-dimensionality of his character, contributing to My Pafology's satirical tone. Go's explanation for his reckless, unlawful behavior ("I ain't had no life") points to how the systemic racism of his society has doomed him to a life of pointless criminality, but the melodramatic tone of his words undermine the truth of their message.



Go and the girl get into the car. He smiles at the news camera trained on him as he turns the keys in the ignition. Just then, there's a loud explosion. For a moment, Go thinks he's been shot. Then the police yank him from the car and throw him on the ground. He asks what happened, and one officer laughs and says the air bag went up. Go looks up at the cameras as the police kick him. He smiles and says, "Hey, Mama. [...] Hey, Baby Girl. Look at me. I on TV."

Go's direct address to the cameras suggests his resignation but also his self-satisfaction—he's on TV! That he is only able to achieve fame and recognition by committing crimes points to Monk's central critique of the publishing industry, which only seems interested in publishing Black authors whose works adhere to a narrow, limiting, and (in Monk's view) offensive portrayal of what it means to be Black in America. Note the language Go uses in his direct address to Mama and Baby Girl ("I on TV")—it will gain deeper significance at the end of Erasure.



CHAPTER 7

It's the middle of July. Monk is sitting in the study when Yul calls him and asks if he's serious about the manuscript he's submitted. Monk, unflustered, says he is. He also points out that he hasn't put his name on it. He tells a hesitant Yul not to include any disclaimer—if the editors can't understand that it's a parody, that's on them.

Later, fretting about money, Monk calls Bill to ask for help with some of Mother's expenses. Bill insists he doesn't have any money with the ongoing divorce. He suggests that Monk put Mother in a home, sell the house, and let Lorraine go. He also tells Monk he's "taken a lover," a phrase that irks Monk. Monk is also irritated to detect a slight "stereotypical lisp."

The next morning, Yul calls back and says that Random House has offered Monk an advance of \$600,000—they love the book and want to meet with "Mr. Leigh." Monk is in disbelief and describes the situation as "really fucked up," but he reluctantly admits that he'll accept the offer. He asks Yul to make up something about Stagg R. Leigh being really shy to delay Random House editor Paula Baderman's request for a meeting.

The manuscript in question is My Pafology. Although Monk's writing My Pafology perhaps signals a new willingness to express some of the outrage and raw emotion he otherwise keeps out of his art, his choice to submit the scathing satire to publishers under a pseudonym reflects his lingering hesitance to fully own and accept those sentiments as his own. He still wants to treat his anger as art and performance rather than genuine emotion.



Superficially, one might interpret Monk's irritation at the slight "stereotypical lisp" he detects in Bill's voice as homophobic. But on a deeper level, Monk's irritation at Bill seems to stem from the jealousy he feels toward Bill's ability (and perhaps also courage) to reinvent himself. In coming out as gay, Bill embraces a facet of his identity he has previously kept hidden from the outside world, and in so doing, he perhaps opens the door to gaining deeper self-knowledge, as well—something Monk, with regard to his confused racial identity, can't (or isn't willing) to do.



Monk sent My Pafology to publishers to criticize the offensive, overly simplistic representations of "real" Black life in America they tend to publish. He thought it would be obvious his novella is a parody—so he's shocked and disturbed at the "really fucked up" outcome of them taking the book seriously. At the same time, he's not in a financial situation to turn down the hefty advance they offer him, so he accepts it, thereby becoming complicit in the system he so hates. Monk may not "believe in race," but he nevertheless finds himself subject to the powerful social and economic forces that mold and perpetuate systemic racism and injustice. Meanwhile, the plot thickens as Monk makes the ludicrous choice to act out the role of Stagg R. Leigh.



Sometime later, Bill calls Monk in the middle of the night and asks him how long Monk has known Bill is gay. Monk says he's known for a while, maybe since high school. Bill wonders if he should tell Mother. Monk asks why Bill would want to bring that drama into his life—it's not like Mother will remember it anyway. In a brief interlude that follows, Monk reflects on how people sometimes place human-made structures in a stream to try to "improve the habitat of **trout**." However, "fish prefer the smooth curves of nature to the hard edges of humans," and so such methods often do more harm than good.

The next morning, Monk takes the Metro to the mall and walks around the National Gallery. He considers the money he's just come into and how he technically doesn't have to teach anymore. As he looks at the art, he considers all the times he had thought of killing himself in his early adulthood. He'd always stopped at the stage of writing the note, unable to see his "silly romantic notions shattered by a lack of imagination." He wonders if his latest novel will make him a sell-out.

Later, after struggling to catch a cab (three empty cars drive right past him) Monk returns home to find Lorraine sitting on the porch steps. Lorraine explains that Mother doesn't recognize Lorraine and has locked and bolted the doors. Monk climbs through an open window in the study. He finds mother in the house holding a pistol—which he later discovers is loaded. Following this incident, Monk takes Mother to a doctor who runs some tests and tells Monk that Mother seems to be experiencing the early stages of Alzheimer's. She suggests moving Mother into a care facility for everyone's sake.

Later, Monk works on a bedside stand while Lorraine puts Mother to bed. The legs of the stand wobble a bit, but Monk doesn't mind—the nightstand is at least "something to feel in [his] hollow stupor." Monk's thoughts drift to a memory of being at the city dock in Annapolis with his family. In the memory, Monk is 12. Lisa is reading a book, and Monk comments that he wants to be a writer when he grows up. But he wants to write serious stuff like Dostoevsky, not like the "crap" that Lisa is reading. Lisa scoffs, but Father says that if Monk says he'll do something, then he'll do it. He "will be an artist," Father explains. "He's not like us." Lisa and Bill, on the other hand, will be doctors. Lisa will be "[a] good one," Father says. He's not sure what kind Bill will be.

Monk comes off as dismissive of Bill in this scene. Although he frames his advice that Bill not tell Mother about his homosexuality as a practical decision, it perhaps betrays Monk's own jealousy at Bill for his willingness to be open about parts of himself that might invite rejection and disappointment. Monk does not have this resolve—that's why he has chosen to perform the role of Stagg R. Leigh rather than admit to his authorship of My Pafology. Monk's meditation on fishing adds to fishing's symbolism, underscoring the clarity and natural ease of nature as compared to the uncertainty and unnatural ways that humans engage with other people and with their surroundings.



Monk's troubling thoughts of suicide are a response to what he considers the unpardonable crime of compromising his artistic integrity for a paycheck. Monk has constructed his entire identity around his commitment to his art. Now that he has betrayed that commitment, can he say with certainty who he is anymore?



The narration frames Monk's struggle to catch a cab is the result of racism—it's implied that these cab drivers failed to stop for Monk because he is Black. Once more, racism continues to affect Monk's life despite his personal rejection of the concept of race. This adds to the novel's broader examination of identity as a combination of how the world views a person and how a person views themselves, particularly with regard to racial identity.



The obvious favoritism Father exhibited toward Monk may have caused bitterness between Monk and his older siblings, but it's clear that favoritism has only disadvantaged Monk in the long run. Whereas Lisa and Bill learned to look inward for purpose and fulfillment and thus grew into functioning, self-assured adults, Monk learned to turn to his father for approval. As a result, he struggles to make peace with—or even know—who he is and what he values. Monk's entire identity is tied up in his father and his father's standard of excellence, and he's just now realizing how negatively this has affected him throughout his life.



CHAPTER 8

Monk is sitting in the study when he stumbles upon a gray box containing a series of love letters addressed to Monk's father, starting in 1955, from an English woman named Fiona. The contents of the letters reveal they met in Korea, where Fiona was a nurse. In a letter dated November 12, Fiona reveals that she is pregnant with Monk's father's child and that she is moving. She doesn't provide her new address and tells Monk's father not to contact her again. She follows this up with a postcard to say that the baby is a girl whom she's named Gretchen. There's an unsent, unsigned letter addressed to Gretchen from Monk's father telling her it was wrong of Fiona to remove him from their lives and that he loves her and wishes he could be a father to her. He tells Gretchen about her half-siblings.

Monk has long idolized his father and derived his own self-worth from this father's approval. Uncovering this secret about his father's affair and the child that resulted from it is therefore emotionally and existentially devastating to Monk. It forces Monk to question everything he has believed to be the truth about his father and about his own identity, the sense of self he built around his fierce desire to please his father.



CHAPTER 9

Monk has always been an Ellison: he had Ellison tastes, "an Ellison way of speaking." His grandfather had been a physician. He liked being an Ellison when he was young but came to resent it as a teenager. Monk's mother's maiden name was Parker, and she came from a family of farmers who lived on the Chesapeake Bay. Monk has a bunch of cousins on that side, "with names like Janelle and Tyrell," whom he barely knows. He saw that side of the family only once, on a visit to their farm house. "They frightened me," Monk recalls. Had he had more life experience, he "would have liked them, found them thriving and interesting," he thinks now. He remembers that Mother always seemed ashamed of her family.

In light of the troubling revelations Monk has just learned about his father, he begins to question all the ways his father has negatively influenced his beliefs, tastes, and sense of self. Monk's reflections on the shame he (and his mother) felt toward his mother's side of the family suggests that he learned to look down on a less refined, cultured form of Blackness, seeing the Parker side of the family as inferior and underachieving, resulting in some degree of internalized racism on Monk's part.



Back in the present, Monk is in the garage looking at the **table** (which is now more of a stool) he's been working on. He considers how his mother must have felt when she read the love letters. Though Monk's father had ordered Monk's mother to burn the contents of the boxes upon his passing, he must have known she'd read them. Monk wonders whether it would be worse for his mother to go on believing that she was wrong to feel inadequate in her marriage or to now know that those feelings were not all in her head.

Monk's question about whether it would be better for his mother to know the truth about his father or to go on believing a lie is really a question about himself: is it better for Monk to go on pretending that the person is father shaped him to be is the best, most authentic version of himself, or should he take a step back and reflect on how the ways his father taught him to see himself and the world are in fact flawed and even self-destructive?



Later, Yul struggles to hold back his excitement over Monk's new book deal, though he's not quite on board with Monk's idea to play the character of "Stagg R. Leigh," ex-con, on his phone call with Paula Baderman. On the phone call later, Monk (as Mr. Leigh) addresses the editor coolly and curtly. He derides the "white people on the beach [who] will get a big kick out of" his forthcoming novel, a comment he knows will excite Paula.

Monk's choice to play the role of "Stagg R. Leigh" on the phone with Paula Baderman, rather than accepting authorship of My Pafology, suggests that he's not yet ready to abandon his artistic integrity. He still clings to sense of self his father's tastes and values carved out for him, and authoring a book like My Pafology would contradict that sense of self.



Later, after the first half of the advance arrives, Monk tells Mother to pack a small bag—he's going to be taking her on a little trip. She suggests they all go to the beach house, and Monk agrees. He tells Mother they'll leave tomorrow. Later, he calls Bill and tells him about his plans to take Mother to the beach house for a few weeks and asks Bill to join them. When Bill protests, Monk says he can bring his new lover, Adam. Bill says he'll see what he can do. After they hang up, Monk considers how Bill is "finally finding himself, [...] but seemingly losing everything else in the process."

The next day, Monk drives himself, Mother, and Lorraine to the beach house. When they arrive, the guard at the gate to the beach recognizes Monk, addressing him by name. He introduces himself as Maynard Boatwright. The name is familiar to Monk, though he doesn't recognize this old man as the buff ex-marine he'd been when Monk was a boy. Later, Mother and Lorraine set to work tidying up the beach house. Monk walks toward the beach and considers how far he should take his Stagg R. Leigh character. He decides he'll talk to the editor a couple more times but not take it any further than that.

On his walk, Monk approaches the house where Professor Tilman once lived. When a woman walks outside, Monk mentions having once known the professor. The woman says the professor was her uncle and that he died three years ago—she inherited the house. Monk introduces himself to the woman, who introduces herself as Marilyn Tilman. When Monk says he's going in the town to do some shopping later, Marilyn suggests she ride along with him. Sitting in the car with Marilyn later, Monk realizes how rare it is for him to be sitting so near a woman he feels attracted to. He feels suddenly self-conscious.

CHAPTER 10

Ten days pass. Monk takes walks with Marilyn, and they admit they like each other. On one occasion, Mother tells Marilyn about Monk's new book. Marilyn mentions this to Monk later when the two of them are drinking wine together on the dock. Monk lies and says the book is a retelling of *The Satyricon*. She says she read one of his earlier books, *The Second Failure*, and liked it. Monk considers how well things are going with Marilyn and wonders if he will "eventually alienate her" and ruin everything. He looks out onto the **water** and sees Lorraine and Maynard drift by in a little skiff, laughing together. He wants to be happy for Lorraine, but all he can think about is Mother in the house alone.

Monk's reflection on all that Bill is "seemingly losing" in his process of "finally finding himself" perhaps reflects Monk's own existential conflict over how his recent discovery about their father's affair calls into question everything Monk has come to believe about himself. Monk has centered his life on becoming a person his father could be proud of, and now he's forced to ask himself whether that person is really so upstanding after all. If Monk tries to find himself—that is, the person he could be on his own terms, independent of his father's approval—it would mean "losing everything" he has ever thought he knew about himself.



Monk's question of how far he should take his Stagg R. Leigh character is about whether he will continue to perform the role of Stagg in order to distance himself from a novel he knows his father would disapprove of, or whether he's willing to assume ownership of that work, break with his father, and become his own person. If Monk continues to play the part of Stagg, My Pafology continues to be pure performance art, and Monk can continue to deny that any part of that work derives from feelings, thoughts, or ideas he genuinely believes in.



Monk's self-consciousness around Marilyn underscores just how rare it is for him to open up to or be vulnerable around others. More often, he hides beyond a persona of artistry and intellectual pretension, even if he doesn't realize it consciously.



Monk's unwillingness to tell Marilyn about My Pafology indicates that he is still too ashamed of what the book might suggest about him to take ownership of it. He continues to hide behind the veneer of high culture and intellectual pretension and to deny any show of raw, inarticulate emotion. And Monk's fear that he will "eventually alienate [Marilyn]" and doom their relationship before it's had a chance to really begin shows that Monk knows this behavioral pattern is destructive—but he doesn't know how to let it go just yet.



Monk's thoughts drift back to his struggles to speak African American vernacular growing up. He'd try, but it would always come out sounding forced. The other kids would describe him as "awkward," noting how he sounded "white" and "stuck up."

Monk's diary segues into a short story he's written, titled "À propos de bottes." The story follows a Black man named Tom who shows up at the NBC building to fill out an application to be on a trivia show called *Virtute et Armis*. He returns the application to the show's receptionist, who hands him a test. Tom easily answers all the questions, which span a range of topics from history to math to science. After Tom's time is up, the receptionist tells Tom that the studio will call him if they decide to use him on the show. Tom says he doesn't have a phone and will just wait here for his results.

Eventually, a producer named Damien Blanc approaches Tom and tells him he did very well on the test and asks if Tom would like to appear on the show that night. Tom agrees. That evening, Tom returns to the NBC building. The staff prep him for TV, covering his face with a dark cream because he "ain't quite dark enough." He looks in the mirror at his newly dark skin and feels "like a clown." He asks if he really has to wear the dark cream on TV, and the makeup staff say yes—if he doesn't, it might confuse the viewers.

Later, Tom takes his place onstage alongside his competitor, a white man from Indiana named Hal Dullard. The show begins. The host, Jack Spades, introduces Hal as a social worker, president of the PTA, and father of two. Spades introduces Tom as "from Mississippi." The game begins. Spades gives Mr. Dullard his question first, asking him to name "a primary color." Dullard answers, "green." The audience gasps. Next it's Tom's turn. Spades asks him, "What is anaphase?" Tom answers correctly and in great detail. Spades acknowledges Tom's correct answer but doesn't congratulate him.

This memory gives the reader additional insight into how and why Monk has come to rely on intellectual pretension in his personal and professional life: it is a weak point he has repurposed as a defense mechanism. Rather than reflect on difficult questions about racial identity, he doubles down on the "white" and "stuck up" way of speaking that alienated him from his Black peers as a child.



Despite Monk's earlier insistence that he does not "believe in race," diary entries like this story draft show that Monk often thinks about race and racial identity in critical, nuanced ways, especially since writing My Pafology and assuming the "role" of Stagg R. Leigh. Virtute et Armis is a Latin phrase, translating to "by valor and weapons." Notably, this is the state motto of Mississippi.



The staff's explanation that Tom "ain't quite dark enough" raises the question of for whom Tom "ain't quite dark enough." Notably, this is a complaint Monk has received from the publishing industry, which repeatedly deems his novels not "Black enough." This story draft thus functions as an exercise for Monk to work through some of his frustration with the publishing industry and his own inner conflicts over race and racial identity.



The ease with which Tom passed the show's entrance test indicates that he is highly intelligent, and his success at answering Spades's questions correctly and thoroughly reaffirms this. The indifference (and perhaps even annoyance) with which Spades responds to Tom's correct answers suggests that Tom is upsetting his (and the audience's) expectations for the intellectual capacity of a Black man. Meanwhile, Dullard's lack of intelligence contradicts his long list of accolades (though it aligns with his last name). In Monk's short story, then, the game show examines racial stereotypes and what happens when people like Tom contradict those.



The show continues in this manner, with Spades posing painfully easy questions to Dullard, who confidently and unwittingly responds with incorrect answers. Tom, meanwhile, continues to answer his own increasingly difficult, specific questions correctly and in great detail. With each correct answer, Spades grows increasingly upset. In the end, Spades grudgingly announces Tom as the show's new champion.

In Monk's short story, the game show symbolizes mainstream attitudes toward race as a whole, but it also reflects Monk's personal experience and frustration with the publishing industry, which only grudgingly "allows" him to assume rank among the intellectual elite. They would rather he (or in the story, Tom) play the role they've decided he should play. The Black man may compete alongside the white man—so long as he doesn't outperform him and upset the status quo.



CHAPTER 11

Mother's state of mind continues to deteriorate. Meanwhile, a romance buds between Maynard and Lorraine. Monk continues to see Marilyn. One day, he knocks on her door and a Black man answers. Marilyn introduces him as Clevon, who greets Monk with a "What's up, brother?" After Clevon leaves, Marilyn explains that she and Clevon used to date and are in the process of breaking up.

Clevon, with his stereotypically Black-sounding name and effortlessly cool vibe ("What's up, brother?") makes Monk feel square and awkward by comparison—just as he did when he was a child. This scene shows how Monk continues to struggle with accepting himself, torn between the intellectual, high-brow person his father shaped him to be and the "Black" personality he's never quite been able to pull off. Although Marilyn assures Monk that she and Clevon are breaking up, it's clear that Monk feels some jealousy or sense of competition with the man.



Later, Monk travels to an assisted care facility outside Columbia, Maryland, where he knows he'll eventually send Mother, though he's waiting for one last episode to convince him that it's time. He tells Bill about it later. After a pause, Bill says that he gets to see the kids one weekend a month now, though the arrangement requires his lover to be out of the house when they visit. Monk commiserates with the unfairness of Bill's situation.

Bill's admission about his struggle to see his kids (recall that Erasure was published in 2001, when gay people in the U.S. experienced considerably more discrimination than they do today) shows Monk that accepting and embracing one's true self isn't without its costs. In Bill's case, his coming out as a gay man may leave him more in touch with himself, but it creates distance and tension between himself and his family.



Monk waits a beat and then tells Bill that they have another sister. He fills him in on some of the details from the letters. Bill says it's "just like him to spring this on us." Monk retorts that Father tried to keep the affair hidden—he'd ordered Mother to burn the papers, after all. But Bill scoffs and reminds Monk that Mother is afraid to boil water for too long lest it start a fire. Monk realizes that Bill is right. And then he understands that Bill has always understood Father better than he has: "Enemies always understand each other better than friends."

Bill's sense of their late father contrasts sharply with Monk's. Bill's observation, "Enemies always understand each other better than friends" suggests that Father's favoritism toward Monk caused Monk to overlook flaws that were obvious to Bill and Lisa. This shows how strongly a person's desire for acceptance, safety, and support can influence their beliefs and actions. Monk's sense of his father isn't positive because his father was necessarily a good person—it's because he made Monk feel worthy and good. Now that Monk is starting to question his former idolatry of his father, it stands to reason that the self he constructed to please his father might too start to crumble.



Later, Maynard stops by to see Lorraine, and they announce that they're getting married. The wedding will be this Saturday—just two days away. They explain that they're old and don't want to waste any time.

Later, Monk goes to Marilyn's house for coffee. Marilyn tells Monk that she and Cleveon are now officially broken up. She pulls Monk in for a kiss, but just then, he sees a copy of Juanita Mae Jenkins's *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* on the table. He brings it up, and Marilyn says she thought it was good. He confronts her about what she thought was good about it, asking if she's ever known anyone who talks like the characters in the book talk. He tells her he thinks the book is "idiotic" and "exploitative" and doesn't understand how a smart person could read it. Marilyn is puzzled by Monk's sudden, inexplicable hostility. Then she becomes angry. She tells him to leave. Monk says he's sorry, but on his way out, he can hear Marilyn start to cry.

Maynard and Lorraine's urgency to get married perhaps instills a sense of urgency in Monk himself—not to get married, but to get better in touch with himself so that he can live a more authentic and fulfilling life.



This tense scene between Monk and Marilyn shows that whatever deep, critical thinking Monk's diary entries undertake with regard to race, racial identity, and his own life, it's not having much of an impact on Monk's behavior. Instead he takes out his frustration and confusion on Marilyn, angrily insulting her for liking literature he claims is "idiotic" and "exploitative" when the person he's truly angry at is himself for producing literature of this ilk while claiming to look down on it. Once more, Monk's failure to fully investigate himself and his deep-seated conflicts heightens his sense of alienation.



CHAPTER 12

Lorraine is spending the night at Maynard's to prepare for the wedding, so Mother's care falls to Monk. This morning is particularly difficult. Mother recognizes Monk and herself, but she's forgotten how to dress herself. Later, when they arrive at Maynard's house for the wedding, Monk feels a twinge of guilt upon realizing that everything has, in a sense, gone exactly according to plan: he has gotten rid of Lorraine so that he can put Mother away in a home and move on with his life.

With the moral, financial issues of what to do with Lorraine and Mother all but solved, Monk is free to move on with his life, even if he hasn't resolved the personal, identity-focused conflicts these issues have inspired in him. He can leave the discovery about his father unresolved and his own personal hang ups about race and racial identity in the past, if he wants. Whether he will continue to examine these issues or will choose to repress them, as he has arguably done his whole life, remains to be seen.



Maynard's house is chaotic, full of clashing personalities and opinions. Maynard's daughter, for one, can't stand Lorraine. Monk chats with Maynard's son-in-law, Leon, who treats Monk judgmentally when he learns that Lorraine is Monk's family's "servant." He asks if the family is rich. Monk answers no, but when he admits that he is taking unpaid time off work and not worried about money, Leon says that means Monk is rich. When Leon bluntly asks Monk, "So, what kind of wedding present you gonna give your servant?" Monk suddenly replies that he's giving Lorraine \$10,000. Leon says nothing but goes across the room to whisper something to his wife. Suddenly, the atmosphere is one of joy.

The resolution to this awkward scene between Monk and Maynard's son-in-law—Monk essentially throws the promise of money at Lorraine's future in-laws to settle a tense moment—points to how people can use money and status to settle personal and interpersonal issues rather than confront and learn from them. Monk is able to do this more easily now that he has money from his book deal.



Monk's thoughts drift back to a memory of the day Father announced his own father's death. Lisa and Bill break down in grief. Monk is 10 and too young to really understand enough to cry. At dinner that night, Lorraine asks if Father wants her to say a prayer, and Father replies bluntly, "Hell no." After Lorraine is gone, Father tells the kids not to let grief push them toward a superstitious belief in God. Grandfather had not been "afraid of the dark," and neither should the children. After a while, Mother, who has been noticeably silent, finally says, "This is not about you."

Back in the present, Mother snaps in the middle of the wedding. She calls Lorraine a "golddigger" and calls the guests "thugs." Lorraine is crying now. Monk apologizes to everyone, explaining that Mother is sick. Then he runs off to the bathroom, where Mother has bolted herself inside. He breaks down the door and carries her away from the house before the ceremony can begin. Later that day, Lorraine stops by the Ellison house to collect her things. She's angry still and refuses to speak to Mother. To Monk, she mutters, "This is the thanks I get." Monk hands Lorraine an envelope containing the \$10,000. Later, Monk calls Bill to tell him he's going to have Mother committed the next day. Bill says he'll fly out.

CHAPTER 13

That night, Monk stays up all night, too afraid to take his eyes off Mother. When Mother wakes up the next morning, she asks where Lorraine is. Monk explains that Lorraine got married last night. After a pause, Monk tells Mother she has to pack a bag today—he's taking her to a hospital.

Later that day, Monk convinces Mother to take a stroll along the beach. As they walk, Mother says how much she misses Lisa, and how she can't believe she's gone. She also says she wishes she were closer to Bill and his children. She notes how Father was too hard on Bill. Monk, in contrast, was "his special child." The conversation upsets Monk. Mother is "so much herself" in this moment. After a while, Monk decides to come clean with her about where he's taking her and why. He describes some of the incidents that have come up recently. Mother accepts this calmly and says she trusts Monk's judgment.

Mother is criticizing Father for using this superficially stoic speech about his own father's condemnation of religion and superstition to elevate himself and his own beliefs. Although Father presents his words as advice to his children about staying strong in the face of grief, he's really just using his father's passing as an opportunity to selfishly validate and enforce his own beliefs. That Monk thinks of this memory now signals that he is continuing to question the high pedestal on which he has held his father (and the man's values and tastes) all these years, and by extension, to question how his (Monk's) embrace of these views may have affected his character negatively. Are Monk's own high tastes and so-called morals just a display of egoism and self-indulgence?



Mother's outburst makes it clear to Monk that he cannot procrastinate admitting her to a facility any longer. Although Mother's disease is in part to blame for the specific insults she hurls against Lorraine, her words also point to the internalized racism and self-hatred she continues to hold inside herself after years of being made to feel inferior in her marriage. The ugliness of Mother's outburst shows Monk the ugliness of his father's elitism and internalized racism—sentiments Monk himself has internalized, even if doesn't consciously recognize them as such.



Monk's honesty with Mother about where he's taking her point to a new, conscious effort to be different from, rather than emulate, his father: he won't lie to and disrespect her the way his father did when he was alive.



Mother's sudden lucidness—she remembers that Lisa is dead and laments cogently and self-assuredly her distant relationship to Bill—makes what Monk knows he must do even harder. That Mother, in her lucid state, describes Monk as "his [father's] special child" adds to Monk's inner turmoil now that he's begun to see the full truth of his father's self-centeredness, and how those negative traits influenced Monk's development and adult self.



In a brief interlude, Monk describes his first **table** saw. It came with a plastic guard, which Monk would “faithfully” use each time, though it would annoy him when the cumbersome shield would interfere with the woodcutting process. Then he eventually started to remove the guard for larger pieces of wood, and eventually he stopped using it altogether, no longer thinking about the risk of potentially losing a finger.

In the novel, Monk’s woodworking symbolizes the act of successfully and straightforwardly communicating one’s character and intentions to others, something he struggles to do in his real life. In this passage, the plastic guard functions as a metaphor for the defenses and pretenses people enact in their interactions with others to avoid being hurt and disappointed. In fact, however, while putting up walls can protect a person from hurt, they ultimately inhibit successful communication, like how the plastic shield interferes with the woodcutting process.



Back in the present, Monk takes Mother to her new home in Columbia. Later, he picks Bill up from the airport. Bill has dyed his hair blond, and Monk hardly recognizes him. At home, Bill showers and then joins Monk in the den. Monk says he’d like to see Mother now. Bill argues that it’s a bit late—it’s nearly six by now—but he gives in. At the care facility, Mother doesn’t recognize Bill or Monk.

Monk hardly recognizes Bill with his new hair because the person he still sees Bill as the false outer persona Bill used to project to the world when he was still hiding his homosexuality.



Later, Yul calls Monk to tell him that a Hollywood producer, Wiley Morgenstein, wants to pay Monk three million dollars for the movie rights to *My Pafology*. But he wants to meet Stagg R. Leigh. Monk hatches a plan to attend a lunch in character as Stagg. Yul is in disbelief at Monk’s ridiculous plan but gives in. He reminds Monk how much money is on the table and tells him not to mess it up. Meanwhile, Monk returns to the box of his father’s personal things and finds an address for Fiona’s sister, Tilly McFadden, who lives in Lower East Side Manhattan.

*With his submission of *My Pafology*, Monk begins to see the same financial success as Juanita Mae Jenkins, whose novel also got a lucrative movie deal. With Mother needing expensive medical care, Monk isn’t in a position to turn down the deal, so he decides to accept it, but with the caveat that he will do so as “Stagg Leigh.” This way, he can continue the charade that he is not a sellout and that *My Pafology* is an intricate work of performance art.*



Monk’s diary contains a dialogue (it’s unclear whether the dialogue is real or imagined) between an editor and Stagg R. Leigh. Stagg insists on changing the title of *My Pafology* to *Fuck*. The editor is aghast and says they can’t do that. Stagg says they’d better, or else the deal is off.

*Monk’s diary entry expresses his mounting frustration—with the industry that is so eager to publish a work as inferior as *My Pafology*, and with himself for abandoning his artistic integrity by writing what he considers to be superficial, offensive drivel. The demand to change the book’s title to *Fuck* signals Monk’s desire to lay the Stagg R. Leigh project to rest—surely, he reasons, the publishing industry has its limits as to how low it will stoop in the name of advancing so-called “raw” works that depict the “real” Black experience.*



CHAPTER 14

Monk worries about the implications of his refusal to accept his own “complicity in the marginalization of ‘black’ writers.” He realizes the irony of his situation: “I was a victim of racism by virtue of my failing to acknowledge racial difference and by failing to have my art be defined as an exercise in racial self-expression.” To make a living and elevate himself, he will have to write a book from the perspective of the type of Black writer the world expects him to be. At any rate, as he prepares for his meeting with Wiley Morgenstein, he realizes that he’s starting to enjoy the “game” he’s playing. Plus, the money is nice.

Bill doesn’t come home that night. When he returns the following morning, Monk confronts him and asks if he’s high on something. He explains that he’s on his way out to see Mother now but can wait longer for Bill if Bill wants to come with. They argue and Bill accuses Monk of being angry at him for being out all night. He angrily tells Monk to go on without him.

At the care facility later, Monk browses the contents of a bookshelf behind the doctor’s desk and notes the many Tom Clancy- and John Grisham-type books. Though they’re not serious literature, they don’t inspire the visceral disgust Monk feels toward *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto*, and he considers why this is. He concludes that the books are well written enough and aren’t presented as being “a representation of [the author’s] race.” And if a person doesn’t like how Tom Clancy writes white people, they can just read about other white people.

Later, the doctor tells Monk that they had to sedate Mother, but that perhaps tomorrow will be better. Monk suddenly imagines that the doctor is Lisa, who urges Monk to take comfort in the fact that at least Mother isn’t suffering. Lisa also urges Monk not to let Bill bother him too much—he’s trying to find himself and “can’t help it if he’s not likeable.” When Monk returns later, Bill is gone. He’s left behind a note that says simply, “FUCK YOU!”

*Monk realizes that regardless of how he conceptualizes race and racial identity, he is marginalized and discriminated against, nevertheless. His need to support himself requires his “complicity in the marginalization of ‘black writers.’” On the other hand, had he never written *My Pafology* in the first place and refused to let his work be defined by racial identity, no publisher would be interested in his work, and he wouldn’t be able to support himself as a writer. In this way, then, Erasure emphasizes how social forces overpower personal will.*



Bill’s guess as to why Monk is truly angry with him seems spot on. Monk isn’t actually upset that Bill is high—he’s bitter that Bill was out all night and enjoying himself, an indication of Bill’s newfound comfort with his true, authentic self.



*Monk finesses some of his ire with *We’s Lives In Da Ghetto* and books like it, and he concludes that it’s not exactly the book itself that he has an issue with but the industry that supports it, and the underlying foundation of systemic racism that informs the publishing industry’s decisions. He takes issue with the fact that white writers like Clancy and Grisham can write mediocre-but-inoffensive books without society seeing those books as defining the singular white experience.*



Monk’s daydreaming signals his overwhelm—the stress of Mother’s worsening health combined with Monk’s ongoing identity crisis is becoming too much for him to bear, and he struggles to remain alert and engaged in the present moment. The detail of Lisa urging him to have compassion for Bill reaffirms how heavily Bill’s self-reinvention weighs on Monk, who seems to envy Bill’s courage to know himself and present that authentic self to the world.



Wiley Morgenstein flies out to D.C. to meet with Stagg R. Leigh. Monk dons a pair of dark glasses and wonders who he's "trying to fool." At lunch, "Stagg" meets Morgenstein and his attractive "assistant," Cynthia. Morgenstein gushes over Stagg's book. When Stagg orders a Gibson to drink, Morgenstein is caught off guard. Stagg asks him if it's because Morgenstein pictured him as more "Black," and Morgenstein uncomfortably confirms that this is the case. Stagg, when asked, insinuates that he was in prison for murder. Monk leaves the lunch satisfied with his performance—and confused at his satisfaction.

Monk's disguise as Stagg R. Leigh contrasts sharply with Bill's new, authentic self. Both brothers boast a new physical appearance, but whereas Bill's lays bare his authentic self, Monk's obscures his true identity. Meanwhile, Monk's satisfaction at his successful performance as Stagg in his meeting with Morgenstein calls into question who Monk's authentic self really is in the first place, as well as the role performance plays in identity.



CHAPTER 15

Monk reflects on the fight that ended his brief affair with Marilyn. It wasn't her poor taste that set him off—it was, perhaps, that "the book reminded [him] of what [he] had become, however covert." Later, Monk and a bemused Yul discuss Monk's demand to change the title of *My Pafology* to *Fuck*. Yul suggests that Monk may be taking things too far. Later, however, he reaches out to Monk to let him know that the publisher has approved the title change.

*Like Monk's anger at Bill, his anger toward Marilyn is less about Marilyn and more about himself: he's angry that her having read and enjoyed the Jenkins book "reminded [him] of" the phony he has become. Meanwhile, Yul's announcement that the publisher has agreed to change the title of *My Pafology* to *Fuck*—a suggestion "Stagg" made only as a joke, certain no publisher would actually take it seriously—sends Monk deeper into the hole he's dug for himself in his "performance art" piece.*



In the mornings, Monk sits down at his desk and tries—with not much success—to write a new novel to redeem himself. One day, Monk receives a call from the National Book Association, the NBA. Carl Brunt, the director, invites Monk to be on the committee to judge entries for the major fiction award the association sponsors, *The Book Award*. Monk agrees.

The invitation to serve on the National Book Association committee offers Monk a chance to redeem himself as a serious author—and under his real name, too.



Later, during a teleconference, Monk meets the other judges on the panel. Wilson Harnet recently wrote a novel about his wife's cancer diagnosis. She ended up not dying and divorced him for sharing all their secrets. Ailene Hoover has written two novels and a short story collection and lives in upstate New York. Thomas Tomad has written several books of short stories that have been well received by the American Association of Incarcerated People Who Write. Jon Paul Sigmarsen is an award-winning writer who lives in Minnesota and hosts a PBS show called *With All This Snow, Why Not Read?* After some back and forth, the judges agree to meet in a couple weeks to discuss whether anyone has read anything promising.

The other judges are caricatures of the sorts of authors favored in the mainstream publishing world. For instance, Harnet is the self-important male author who discounts other people for the sake of his art; meanwhile Thomas Tomad's work with incarcerated people represents the intersection between art and social justice, still popular in the present day.



Monk's diary segues into a hypothetical conversation between Rauschenberg and Willem de Kooning. Rauschenberg gives de Kooning a piece of paper and asks him to draw something on it, explaining that he will then erase whatever de Kooning has drawn. Willem de Kooning obliges, and Rauschenberg erases the drawing. He shows de Kooning the erased drawing, which now has Rauschenberg's name on it. It's Rauschenberg's work now—he put more work into erasing it than de Kooning put into drawing it, after all. He calls it "Erased Drawing" and tells de Kooning he has sold it for \$10,000.

Meanwhile, Monk starts to receive boxes of submissions for *The Book Award*. He reads the first book and loves the experience of reading it, though the book isn't all that great. He reads more books and finds all of them to be "sterile, well-constructed, predictable fare." He wonders whether he's "jaded" and realizes he must try hard to find something inside himself that "could still be amazed by the dull and commonplace."

On Monk's way out the door to visit Mother, the phone rings. He picks it up. It's Linda Mallory asking if he wants to have sex. This time, he agrees to come by her hotel room later that night. They have sex, and Monk finds Linda to be painfully "self-conscious" about her performance. Still, he finds that he "respect[s] her enough not to pity her." After she climaxes (but he does not), he suggests they just watch a movie together. They flip through the channels, landing on a noir film, and Linda soon falls asleep.

CHAPTER 16

Monk laments the poorly edited submissions he reads, noting how overly long and bloated some of the novels are. He enjoys some of them, and he even reluctantly admits that some are better than anything he could have written. Later, he and the judges gather for their first conference to discuss submissions. Two judges suggest that they shortlist books written by colleagues. Monk suggests they wait until all the submissions come in before making any decisions.

Christmas comes and goes, and Mother's health continues to deteriorate. Monk learns that *Fuck* will be released early "because of the great interest." Then he receives a padded envelope in the mail that January with a bound galley of *Fuck* and a request that it be considered for *The Book Award*. Now he's in a real pickle: he won't admit to being Stagg R. Leigh, and yet he can't disqualify himself from judging it without revealing his dual identity. He decides to ignore the problem, assuming that none of the judges would deign to take the book seriously.

Rauschenberg and de Kooning were two 20th-century artists. The work Monk describes in this conversation actually exists. Monk's meditation on it here points to the intersection of creation and destruction, suggesting that a work of art (or a person's identity, for that matter) come to be through the creation of something new or the erasure of something old. Monk, in drafting this hypothetical dialogue, seems to reflect on whether his playing the part of Stagg R. Leigh is an act of artistic creation—or a destructive erasure of Monk's own self, either as a person, an artist, or perhaps both.



Monk's experience reading the book submissions reaffirms his love of reading, but it also shows him how his unreasonably high (and perhaps arbitrary) standards have distanced him from that love, leaving him perpetually underwhelmed and critical.



Monk perhaps "respect[s]" Linda not despite her self-consciousness but because of it: she is confident enough in herself to appear vulnerable and uncertain in front of others, something Monk isn't able to do himself.



Monk's experience judging the book submissions simultaneously reaffirms his own skill and humbles him. In the comfort of his own home, beyond reach of the industry that wishes to limit his artistry to an expression of his racial identity, he can be the person of diverse interests and expertise he wants to be—he can be more than his race, both as a critic and as a person.



*The renewed sense of validation that Monk's participation on the committee for *The Book Award* gave him comes to a halt with the request for *Fuck* to be considered for the award. At once, Monk is reminded of the artifice of the publishing industry, its marginalization of Black writers, and his own complicity in that marginalization. Tension mounts as the reader (and Monk) waits to see whether the committee will choose to consider *Fuck* or reject it.*



Meanwhile, Monk self-isolates, ignoring letters he receives from students, colleagues, and potential employers. One day, he sits in the study and imagines a hypothetical reading given by Stagg Leigh. Stagg wears baggy pants and a black silk shirt. A young white woman from the Friends of the Book Society introduces him. Some older white women sit in the front row, appearing nervous. Stagg takes the stage and loudly exclaims, “Fuck!” Then he segues into the reading. Later (in reality), Kenya Dunston selects *Fuck* for her book club. Unfortunately for Monk, this means Stagg Leigh must appear on the Kenya Dunston Show to plug the book.

Monk—and Stagg Leigh—travel to New York, Monk for his meeting with *The Book Award* judges, and Stagg for his appearance on the Kenya Dunston Show. At the committee meeting, Monk and the other judges discuss the books they’ve read. Ailene Hoover asks if any of them have read *Fuck* yet, and everyone except Sigmarsen says they have. Those who’ve read it (minus Monk) agree that it will at least make their top-20 list. Monk feels sick to his stomach.

The next day, Monk takes a cab to the address of Tilly McFadden’s apartment. A shirtless, tattooed white man (the skinhead) opens the door. The man is unfriendly, and Monk notes a crucifix next to a swastika on the wall. When Monk tells the man he’s looking for Tilly, the man says she’s dead. Gretchen is still alive, though. Monk tells the man that Gretchen is apparently his half-sister. In response, the man (using a racial slur) says he knew Gretchen was part Black. Monk offers to pay the man to take him to Gretchen’s house, and the man eventually agrees.

Monk follows the man (the skinhead) several blocks over to a different brownstone. He hands the man cash, and then the man walks away. Monk rings the bell for Gretchen Hanley’s apartment. After a pause, the door buzzes, and Gretchen—his half-sister—lets him inside. The apartment is small and disheveled, and Monk discerns that the woman isn’t doing well. A baby sits in the corner. Monk introduces himself to Gretchen and explains that he’s her half-brother. Gretchen tells him the baby is her granddaughter whom she watches while her daughter works. Then when Gretchen’s daughter returns, Gretchen goes to work. That’s how it is every day. She asks Monk what he does for work, and Monk tells her he’s a writer. “How wonderful,” Gretchen replies coldly.

Monk’s self-isolation reflects the anxiety he feels as he waits to see whether the other committee members will accept or pass on Fuck as a submission for The Book Award. Meanwhile, his appearance on the Kenya Dunston Show forces him deeper down the hole he began to dig himself into when he first decided to perform the role of Stagg Leigh rather than own up to his authorship of My Pafology/Fuck. Monk has repeatedly had the chance to give up the performance and come clean, but he perpetuates it anyway—and why? Does he really think that Stagg R. Leigh is a work of performance art he has created to make a point to the publishing industry? Or does he realize that performing the role of Stagg will earn him more money in the long run?



Monk’s failure to come clean about his authorship of Fuck has gotten him into a hole he can no longer dig himself out of—the judges’ practically unanimous approval of Fuck means that it will be likely be considered for The Book Award.



Monk’s unpleasant interaction with the skinhead reinforces the reality that even if Monk himself rejects the concept of race, racism still affects him on a personal and systemic level. Ironically, his complicity in that system enables him to fare well in it: he is able pay the skinhead to do his bidding due to the influx of expendable cash he has from accepting the publishing house’s advance for My Pafology.



Monk’s father did not uphold his obligation to support Gretchen, and as a result, she has not had the life of opportunity and privilege that Monk and his siblings had. Monk’s uncomfortable meeting with Gretchen further challenges Monk’s previous assumptions about his father. It also adds nuance and complexity to the novel’s examination of race and privilege. Gretchen may be passably white, but her poverty has held her back where Monk’s relative wealth has allowed him to circumvent some of the roadblocks that systemic racism would otherwise throw his way.



Monk dislikes Gretchen, but he understands her bitterness. He hands her the letter their father wrote but never sent to her. He explains that their father wanted to be in Gretchen's life but couldn't find her. Gretchen replies simply that Monk found her, and Monk can offer nothing in response to this. Impulsively, Monk takes out his checkbook and writes Gretchen a check for \$100,000. He claims their father wanted her to have it. Gretchen asks Monk if he thinks the money will make everything better. He says he doesn't think so, then he leaves.

Gretchen notes how easily Monk found her to point out that their father's abandonment of her was not involuntary. In fact, Monk's father could have fulfilled his obligation to help Gretchen and her mother—he simply chose not to.



CHAPTER 17

Monk walks back to his hotel and considers how his newly discovered family members have "generated new levels of irony and resonance to [his] plight as Stagg Leigh." As he walks, he passes a billboard that reads "KEEP AMERICA PURE." Later, Stagg Leigh leaves his hotel room dressed casually in black clothing and a black fedora. Ailene Hoover enters the elevator on Stagg's way down and asks if she knows him—he seems familiar. "I suppose I have one of those faces," Stagg says in response.

Monk's meeting with Gretchen and the skinhead have added "irony and resonance to [his] plight as Stagg Leigh" because it has reinforced his relative economic privilege—an advantage he has further secured through his complicity in an oppressive system ruled and perpetuated by wealth. Monk's remark to Hoover ("I suppose I have one of those faces") is a wry joke meant to point out Hoover's unconscious racism—Monk (as Stagg) is implicitly suggesting that to Hoover, all Black people look alike. At the same time, he is implicitly pointing out his ongoing identity crisis.



Monk (as Stagg) arrives at the studio and waits around backstage before the Kenya Dunston Show is set to begin. Yul is there and pretends not to recognize Monk as a joke. Monk reminds him that he'll be behind a screen (because Stagg is supposedly a vigilante on the run), so his physical disguise doesn't matter all that much.

Monk's appearance on the Kenya Dunston Show loosely mirrors Go's appearance on the Snookie Cane show in My Pafology. Gradually, there is more overlap between Monk's and Go's stories, signaling how Monk's performance as Stagg Leigh is gradually causing him to lose his sense of self.



Finally, the show begins. The audience sings along to the theme music. Kenya Dunston introduces Stagg Leigh and gushes over his book. When she asks him questions, though, he only gives one-word answers in response and refuses to elaborate on his inspiration for the story. Kenya uncomfortably makes a joke about Stagg being shy. During a commercial break, she yells at the producer, demanding to know what the deal is. The producer, Weiß, urges Stagg to loosen up a bit. But after the commercial break, Stagg continues the monosyllabic act. Finally, Kenya opens her copy of *Fuck* and reads an excerpt from the graphic scene in which Go rapes Cleona. The production staff bleep out the passage's many expletives. When she finishes, the audience cheers. Afterward, Yul gives Stagg a thumbs up, and Stagg (as Monk) feels ashamed.

Monk's refusal to cooperate with Kenya Dunston simultaneously reaffirms his discomfort with and his commitment to his role as Stagg Leigh (a jaded criminal like Stagg wouldn't humor Kenya or Fuck's majority-white readership). Kenya and her audience's embarrassingly unflinching approval of a violent rape scene reinforces the implicit racism of readers who outwardly proclaim their support for Black representation in the arts—in failing to condemn Go's reprehensible behavior, they essentially suggest that it is expected and acceptable for Black people to behave in this manner.



CHAPTER 18

Monk flies back to D.C. feeling hopeless and ashamed to the point of being suicidal. The passenger seated next to him on the plane, an Australian woman, notices his dejected mood. She suggests he visit Australia. There are places in the desert that are so awful they'd likely make anything back here seem great by comparison. She explains that her father used to tell her, "There isn't anything so bad that seeing something worse won't make better."

Back in Washington, Monk reconvenes with the other judges over the phone and is horrified to learn that they're all over the moon about *Fuck*. "The best novel by an African American in years," one observes. It makes the judges' top-five list.

Later that week, Monk visits Mother and they listen to classical music. They dance, and Mother reminisces about Father. She sensed that she annoyed him at times, but she knew that he loved her—"because why would he have hidden his feelings so," she reasons. Still, she recalls having "felt so small" at times. Then Mother takes a deep breath and notes that she smells like mentholated spirits. She laments her earlier promise to herself never to "become old and smell of mentholated spirits," but here she is. She asks if Monk has promised himself anything, and Monk replied that he once vowed to never "compromise [his] art." Later, Monk tries to reach Bill multiple times, but he gets no response.

Monk considers how he has "reconfigure[d]" and "disintegrate[d]" himself so that there are now "two bodies of work, two bodies, no boundaries yet walls everywhere." Now he fears he must face the consequences. Later, he considers the possibility of killing Stagg Leigh—though, of course, the problem with that plan is that *he* is Stagg Leigh. He created him "well enough that [Stagg] created a work of so-called art." Monk resolves not to let *Fuck* win *The Book Award*, even if he must destroy himself in the process.

Monk's troubling thoughts of suicide underscore how significantly his performance as Stagg Leigh has affected his emotional wellbeing and splintered his sense of self. In writing My Pafology, he has comprised his artistic integrity so greatly that he no longer recognizes himself, nor considers his life worth living.



With a majority of Monk's fellow judges expressing their enthusiastic approval of Fuck, Monk's predicament intensifies, and his disillusionment with the publishing industry (and with society as a whole) grows. He thought Fuck's unserious tone would be obvious, yet it continues to fool people who ought to know better.



Mother's explanation that Father must have loved her because he "hid his feelings so," not letting her see if she inspired feelings of annoyance or frustration in him, adds to the novel's larger examination of identity, authenticity, and familial obligation. She's suggesting that if a person truly cares for another, they prioritize that care over their own emotions—that is, they show their care through their actions, not necessarily through their feelings. This seems to resonate with Monk, who has thus far justified his writing of My Pafology/Fuck by insisting to himself that he doesn't believe in what the book represents—he's simply a reluctant participant in an unjust industry that has left him with no other option to support himself. But Mother's words here suggest that Monk's intentions don't override his actions.



Monk's conflicted relationship with Stagg R. Leigh comes to a head as he realizes his ideological or aesthetic disapproval of what My Pafology/Fuck represents isn't enough—in continuing to go along with the Stagg R. Leigh performance, and in penning My Pafology/Fuck in the first place, he has gravely compromised his artistic integrity.



Christmas and New Year's come and go. By mid-January, *Fuck* is number one on the *New York Times* bestseller list. Monk reads a laudatory review of the book written by Wayne Waxen, who speaks of the "sheer animal existence" of Van Go Jenkins's life and how "well drawn" and real the characters are. "Fuck," Waxen declares, "is a must read for every sensitive person who has ever seen these people on the street and asked, 'What's up with him?'"

Monk meets his fellow judges for lunch in New York. He listens as they dismiss the four finalists other than *Fuck* one by one. Monk tries to turn them off *Fuck*, deeming it "offensive, poorly written, racist and mindless." But his efforts are in vain. "I would think you'd be happy to have the story of your people so vividly portrayed," Hoover says in response. In the end, it's decided: *Fuck* is the winner.

In his hotel room later, Monk lies on the bed and considers why he created Stagg in the first place, and he feels angry "with [his] world." He also knows that it won't be long before he's exposed. At the ceremony later, all the judges for all the different prize categories sit at tables with the rich donors. Monk is introduced to several CEOs at his table and jokes, "I feel generally out of place." Everyone laughs. Some of them try to get Monk to reveal *The Book Award* winner before it's officially announced, but he refuses. They joke about "you artists and your integrity," which prompts a sharp, short laugh from Monk.

Finally, with great ceremony, Wilson Harnet takes the stage and announces this year's winner: *Fuck* by Stagg R. Leigh. Monk stands and makes his way to the stage, feeling as though he's wading in quicksand. Cameras flash as spectators murmur to one another in confusion. "It's a black thang maybe," Harnet offers to the audience as explanation for why Monk might be approaching the stage.

Monk approaches the stage, and all his past, present, and future faces flash before his eye. Stagg addresses him, asking him how "it feel[s] to be free of one's illusions." Monk, as he approaches Harnet and the microphone, says, "The answer is *Painful and empty*." Harnet, confused, calls out for help. Monk looks at the television cameras before him and says, "Egads, I'm on television."

Waxen's review of *Fuck* mirrors the glowing reviews of *We's Lives In Da Ghetto* that Monk scoffed at the beginning of *Erasure*. In short, he has become the spineless, sell-out author he once despised. Increasingly, he realized that he cannot continue to justify *My Pafology/Fuck* as performance art—in fact, it is merely proof of Monk's complicity in an unjust system.



Monk's worst nightmare comes true: not only has *Fuck* fooled a group of people who are supposed to be intelligent and discerning in their tastes, but it has risen to the very top, earning a prestigious literary award Monk adamantly believes it does not deserve. The irony of Hoover's remark is that in suggesting that Monk ought to be happy about the committee's choice to give voice to "the story of [his] people," it is effectively silencing the voice of its minority judge.



Monk created the persona of Stagg to ridicule the publishing industry for its systemic racism and disingenuous embrace of so-called Black stories, and now he has become the butt of his own joke. Not only has *Fuck* failed to resonate with the publishing industry in the manner Monk intended, but it has revealed Monk himself to be just as fraudulent and complicit as the very people he set out to criticize.



Harnet's nervous explanation for why Monk might be making his way to the stage—"It's a black thang maybe"—points to his implicit bias and the systemic racism of the industry he represents. Tension builds as the reader (and perhaps Monk himself) is left to wonder what Monk will say, if anything, once he reaches the stage.



Monk, in approaching the stage to accept the award as Stagg, becomes "free of [his] illusions," bridging the distance between his Monk persona and his Stagg persona, signaling that he has finally abandoned his previously held belief that he is above artistic compromise or that he can reject the concept of race and operate outside of unjust systems that enforce it. His declaration of "Egads, I'm on television" mirrors the final words of *Go*, signaling Monk's surrender to the fate a society governed by systemic racism has forced on him. He, like *Go*, will play the role society has carved out for him, limiting and demeaning as it may be.





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